



UNCOVERING

Maggie

KT MORRISON

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About the Author

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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UNCOVERING MAGGIE

A MAGGIE novel.

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Written by KT Morrison

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Albany

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 21ST

MAX WOKE before the alarm sounded. Didn't get much sleep at all in the last hour what with the impending day's schedule. He'd woken at 2:13, drifted, reawaken at 3:23, now he was awake yet again and the alarm set for 4:15 would sound shortly.

In his arms, warm and light and silky soft, was the love of his life. During high school, he'd dated close to twenty girls. Had sex with nine of them. Steady-dated two of them. Never had he been in love. Not until a fateful frat party in his first year at Farmingham had nudged young Maggie into his life had he ever considered what love really was. He'd been infatuated with girls before. Hell, he'd been infatuated with Maggie—but it had never been love until her.

Last night they'd had sex without Cole. Just the two of them in bed together like a normal engaged couple, like the couple they were at the beginning of this school year. Dinner at Altieri's for two. Quiet talk, holding hands, looking in each other's eyes. They didn't talk about Cole, didn't talk about Jay, didn't talk about Max watching her with her other men. They talked about themselves, the wedding, the wedding dress, Ken and the video (he shrugged, said, Who knows? Those things can sometimes just shit the bed). They talked about her attending law school. Shit, it *was* a good idea. She was a talented artist, a brilliant musician, but it didn't consume her. It wouldn't be something that would fuel her fire for the rest of her life. Art was just something she excelled at, not something that made her breathe. Maggie's grades were top in her class. She qualified for law school. Her accomplishments outside of school were noteworthy for an Admission

Council. There was time for the application, time for the LSAT. If she wanted to go to Harvard, she would go to Harvard.

At dinner he left out his shortcomings. Left out the implication he failed her by taking a job with her father's help. Honestly didn't see that one coming. Seemed the emotions of their sexual journey stirred some internal cauldron and its hot stew was starting to spill over the edges. He would keep an eye on that for her.

So, avoiding conversations about his future and their dirty present, last night had been almost magical. Wondered if she was up to something which was a terrible thing to think. But she had given him a beautiful night, and it was a gleaming gem amongst the dirty ones of the previous weeks. Perhaps she knew it was needed.

After dinner, they'd wandered back to campus hand in hand. Jessie was away in Brattleboro for the weekend, staying with a new boyfriend who attended VSU, so they had the room for the night. They'd made love. Didn't do it dirty, didn't say awful things to each other; no slut talk, no mention of her other lover's abilities and endowments. They kissed for half an hour. His hands traveled her while she was clothed.

They undressed each other, still kissing, drawing out the evening in dilatory luxury. Pleasure was given to him in a long, amaranthine blowjob. Maggie's already prodigious oral skill had been polished even brighter by exploring with other men. But he'd pushed that thought away, as exciting as it was, and reciprocated the eye contact she'd demanded while her mouth kept him teetering on the edge of a dangerous orgasm for almost an hour. Then, when she had every muscle in his body seized like twisted cable, she'd rewarded him, letting him erupt in her mouth, staring into his eyes while she swallowed every drop. They'd laughed and cuddled.

He went down on her soon after; she writhed in the sheets, called his name. She came. Immediately he'd got between her legs and made love. She came again. This time in missionary. Maggie, always sexual, had become a primed beast. In tune with her sexuality in a way that was startling. Using her mind or whatever tricks she had—shit, maybe it was his own skill, could you imagine?—whatever the reason, she'd come three times with him between her legs. Missionary position with Max was not usually orgasm-inducing.

Her sweet thighs stroked up and down his hips, her nails scratched his back. She told him to come inside her and he did. Ate her out again, his

seed spilling from her slit. That also made her come, crying out his name as she did. They made love four more times. He came each time and so did she. She rode him; he had her on all fours, spooning with her, one bare foot of hers planted on a sketch posted on her wall. No anal.

Sometime after midnight they'd fallen asleep together, under her sheets, table lamp on, her nestled in his arms, face-to-face, her chin on his shoulder.

His heart burst with happiness.

Sleep was fitful with the light on. Despite the exhausting events of the evening a deep and much-needed sleep never came to him.

He inhaled deeply just to feel the slow sticky seal expand on their chests, his skin gaining more ground on Maggie's creamy breasts squashed against him. His hand searched under the sheets behind her, left and right, finding his phone, then bringing it up to her shoulder so he could read the screen.

4:14

It was time.

Waiting for that last minute to tick over he watched her sleeping face. Sweet and placid, the curves and geometry absolute perfection, it was hard to believe that three weeks ago she was entirely his. Still capable now of heart-swelling winsomeness, a glimmer of something ungentle flickered in her eyes this past ten days and he had to extinguish it. It was the spark that ignited ideas like attending law school, and while attending law school was something positive, her revelation of the decision had a metallic, pitiless taste.

At the first sounding of his alarm's digital wind chime his thumb closed it off. Maggie stirred in his arms, regardless. A frown creased her sleepy face, her lips pursed, and she made displeased little-girl sounds in her throat, her arms circled him tighter. She grunted a sound that sounded like No. Lips pressed to her forehead in a long gentle kiss, he hugged her back, and she stretched her body out to press more of it against him.

His dick stirred, squashed between them now, hanging down and pressed hard by her trim tummy. There wasn't time, but he marveled for a moment, smilingly, at her ability to conjure up his demons when he'd come inside her body five times in the last six hours, and was frankly a little sore. His prostate ached and the skin of his penis stung.

When he tried slipping his arm out from under her she grunted with displeasure again, her face pinching in a comical scowl.

“Maggie...”

She grunted, “No.”

“I have to go.”

“Stay with me,” she whispered.

His heart swelled with love again, his cock too, and against better judgment his lips found hers. They kissed for a moment, but despite the eagerness for him to stay, her lips grew tired and she drifted asleep. She woke again though when he slipped his arm farther.

“No,” she said with cute demanding.

He had her smiling, and his arms slipped free, but her hands clamored for him and she climbed his body as he sat up. Her weight sent them both onto the bed again, Maggie on top, her mouth clamped on his nipple. He ran his fingers through her uniformly russet hair and let her suckle and kiss at him.

“Maggie, I have to get going.”

“You sure?” she said, wiggling her hips so her tummy squirmed on the rock hard erection pressing into her.

“Mm, I’d love to but I think it needs a rest.”

“You can’t keep up with me?”

“I know your tricks. Challenging my manhood won’t make me stay.”

“Yes, it will,” she giggled, gripped both her hands on his shoulders and pressed her cheek to his chest. “I’ll get a man who won’t leave my bed. I’ll get a man that can give it as many times as I need it.”

It stabbed him good. “Maggie...”

“I’m kidding,” she said, climbing his body higher and coming face to face with him, her narrow, sleepy eyes looking down on him from above.

“No, you’re not.”

Her lips lowered to his, pressed them. She said, “If I do, I’ll tell you all about it.”

“Promise me you’ll be good while I’m gone.”

“I promise.”

“Promise what?”

“I promise I’ll be a good girl,” she said, eyes closing, her body settling against his, then slipping to the side.

He crawled out from under her, pulled the sheets so she would be covered. Got dressed at the side of her dorm room bed, eyes on her sleeping shape the whole time. When he was ready, his travel bag slung over his

shoulder, he sat on the edge of the bed, pressing the mattress down, making her body lean against his knee. The smooth pale point of her shoulder peeked above the hem of the sheets he'd pulled over her and he kissed her there.

"I love you so much, Maggie Becker," he said quietly.

Her eyes were closed, but she smiled wide, her lips making a popping bubble sound as they parted over her white teeth.

"I love you so much, Max Milton."

While bending over her he wrapped her in his arms and she snuggled against him. They kissed fully and held it a long while, breathing each other in.

When they parted, she said, "You give your mom and dad big huge hugs from me, okay? Tell them I love them."

"I promise," he said.

"I'll miss you."

"I'll be back on Monday. I guess I'll see you on Monday night."

He kissed her forehead, loved its warmth against his lips, stood and clicked off the table lamp and put the room in dark. Sounds of her naked body under the sheets lured him back, but his phone dinged.

Cole: I'm out front fucker 420 in the morn

He laughed silently, texted back.

Max: be right out

IT WAS an hour and a half drive from the Green Mountains into Albany. Max slept most of the way, rocking back and forth in the front seat of the Jeep while tinny music bashed from Cole's iPhone sitting in the cupholder.

When he woke up, he saw pre-dawn light painting pale geometric shapes on the top sides of low, grim, city buildings. He blinked his eyes awake, sat upright in the Jeep's seat. His breathing was heavy and slow.

Traffic was light, just blue-collar workers on their way home from midnight shifts being buffeted by semis rolling probably for thirty-six hours straight. As he came more awake he stretched his neck around, inhaled loudly over top of Cole's iPhone music, said, "Holy shit, are we in Albany?"

Cole, in the driver's seat, elbow on his window ledge, bent wrist draped over the steering wheel, said, "Yeah, real nice—ask your friend to drive you in the middle of the night to the airport then you sleep the whole way."

"Shit, sorry."

It was true. He got into the Jeep back at Farmingham and the last thing he remembered was rolling out of the campus, driving down the village's main street, and then that first section of country road where it seemed like they were getting swallowed up by the tall trees. Then he was in Albany. Driving on the highway.

"What time is it?" he said, phone tucked away somewhere in his pants pocket, sealed shut by his seatbelt, Cole's busted stereo showing nothing but a dead display.

"We got lots of time, let me get you breakfast."

And as he said that he got both hands on the wheel, one hand darting to his indicator, sending a glance then over his shoulder and merging off to the right and exiting the highway.

They curled the exit ramp, hissed under a glowing yellow Denny's sign on a rust colored steel pole extending high above. The parking lot was empty but for a half-dozen vehicles and Cole put the Jeep out alone under the pale amber glow of a lamppost.

They crossed the frigid lot, and he noticed despite the temperature, Cole wore shorts and flip-flops. He'd bundled up in a flannel, and a bulky Farmingham Lacrosse hooded sweatshirt. Ball cap turned backwards, he sported a scruffy beard and his long blonde hair fluttered in the chilly wind. Max was dressed for travel; clean chinos, plaid button-down and a duffel coat.

Cole led the way, hands in pockets, eyes half-lidded in lazy confidence. A plump young waitress rushed them menus, and she was awkward near handsome Cole.

He said, "Coffees," without a smile, wagging two extended fingers and then taking his hat off while she scampered off like a frightened mouse. Cole tied his thick hair back in a bun using an elastic he wore on his wrist.

“What’d you do last night?” he said, rubbing his cheeks and his eyes.

“Dinner. Back to Keegan.”

“You guys do it?” he chuckled, eyes turned down to the huge menu he opened.

Max laughed too, watching Cole carefully. He didn’t seem bothered that Max slept with Maggie. Of course, he shouldn’t. Maggie would be Max’s wife. “Five times,” he said.

Cole’s eyes moved over the breakfast menu and he smiled honestly. “Aww,” he cooed. “My little Maggie.”

Max continued, eyes still on Cole while he read. “Wore me out.”

“Yeah, dude. Maggie is a demon.”

“Uh-huh,” he said, studying him. “She blew me for an hour.”

Cole closed his eyes and leaned back in the booth, still holding the menu. His shoulders shook with a quiet chortle, eyebrows high and mirthful. “God, she is good at that.”

A red spark lit in Max’s eye. He twitched. With a sharp inhale he swiped up his own menu. “You paying?”

“It’s on me, bro,” Cole said.

Max’s eyes went up and down his menu like he was reading it though he knew what he would order. He shook his head with disdain, going over Cole’s agreement on Maggie’s oral skills, hearing it repeat in his ears. If this were a movie, the hero would stand up and pop Cole one. But this wasn’t the movies and life was way more complicated than a plot could ever figure and Jesus Christ, he’d asked for that response, didn’t he? While no man should ever know how his future wife sucks other cocks well, it still excited him.

Menu set down, he said, “She is good at that, isn’t she?”

Cole made a face, eyebrows high in awe. He turned, signaled the waitress. “Yeah, man. I mean, right?”

The girl was there immediately, nervous smile, two rosy nickels staining her cheeks. She flipped their cups and filled them with steaming coffee. Cole said, “Lumberjack Slam. Max ...?”

“Moons Over My Hammy.”

The girl collected the menus, batted her eyes, scampered away again.

“It’s not just me?”

“Maggie?”

“Yeah.”

“No, Max. She’s unbelievable. Like, I mean ... the best ever. There was this one girl in first year, who ... yeah, she was good,” he said, looking up at the stucco tile ceiling, reminiscing. “But, Maggie *loves* it. You know? *Loves* it.”

“She does. No other girl is close,” he said competitively.

Cole nodded. “Like, she ...” his eyes darted to see if they were overheard, but no one sat nearby. Cole leaned closer, “She takes it deep,” he whispered, “but still, you know, uses her tongue. Her throat too. Squeezes my cock ...”

Max felt uncomfortably hard for some reason. This was an awful conversation, but he was enthralled. “I know,” he agreed.

“Some girls, like, won’t ... don’t want to ...” his voice had dropped to a soft whisper, “cause they’ll say, they don’t like uncircumcised guys or, you know, I’m too thick or whatever. That night by the fire ...? Best blowjob I ever had. She takes it out, gets right to it ... does things I’ve never felt. Ever. Lets me come in her mouth ...”

“I know ...”

Cole shook his head. “She’s fucking unreal, man,” he laughed and leaned back in the booth again. “God ... unreal,” he repeated.

Max leaned back as well. They both looked across the table at each other, silent and unmoving, steam rising from their coffee the only action. His heart raced. Talking about Maggie like this got his blood pounding. Hearing her spoken about in such low parameters had his fingertips tingling. Anger sizzled through his extremities, and though Cole was his best friend, he narrowed his eyes and clenched his jaw.

A smirk slowly, hesitatingly, pulled one side of Cole’s mouth, and his eyes gleamed. “This got weird, huh?”

Max unbuttoned the toggles of his coat, opened it. “I think it got weird a long time ago,” he said, sitting straight and shrugging his arms out.

Cole said, “Maggie is one amazing human being.”

“I know. I’m very lucky,” Max said, whitening his coffee from a stainless steel creamer.

Cole sat forward, hand held out, paused, waiting for the creamer when he was done. Max passed it, added sugar from a torn packet.

Max sipped his coffee, watching Cole. Asking his friend to back off would backfire. Maggie wanted him. If Max were to forbid it, her lust for their friend wouldn’t cease. Resentment would set in. Not unbearable,

probably survivable. Better to prune and cultivate her three-way relationship, make it take the shape he wanted. When the time was right, he would salt the soil.

“Thanks for taking me to the airport.”

“Any time, Max. Everything okay at home?”

“Yeah. They missed me on the break, and we’ve got ... family things to discuss ... so ...”

“Serious?”

“God, no. Wedding, finances, this thing with my sister,” he rolled his eyes, indicating there was some drama not worth going into, though there was none at all. “What are you doing this weekend?”

“Drilling Maggie. LSATs. She wants help studying.”

“That’s good.”

“Hey, Max?” Cole leaned to look in his eyes. “I swear that was not my idea.”

“She told me.”

“I never even mentioned it. I thought she wanted to be an artist, or whatever. Do something creative.”

“Me too.”

“Like mother, like daughter,” Cole said.

“God, I hope not.”

“You kidding? Carol’s a beast.”

Max laughed. “A beast?”

“Dude. You ever read up on her? She’s a legal legend. I mean, if you’re into corporate law. And I guarantee you she drains Martin’s python on the reg. Probably more than he wants.”

“Gross.”

“I bet that mansion’s got a room underground like the Bat Cave, full of whips and chains, harnesses, ball gags ...”

Max said, “Strap-ons?”

Cole collapsed in laughter in the booth, eyes closed, clapped his hands. “Right?”

“But Maggie is so sweet.”

“Fuck, she is,” Cole agreed.

“She couldn’t gut some company, or put people out of work.”

Cole shrugged. “I don’t know. I suppose not.”

“She’s not Carol.”

Their food arrived, the waitress putting a hot plate of food in front of each of them, then folding her hands at her apron, saying, "Can I get you more coffee?"

Cole nodded. The girl beamed, liking being at their table, and the initial shock of interacting with a guy as handsome as Cole calming.

"Right up," she said.

Cole said to Max, "It's a good decision though."

"Law? I agree. It just came out of nowhere ..."

"She never mentioned it before?"

"Never."

The waitress returned and poured their coffee. "Got enough syrup?" she asked.

Max said they did and thanked her, and she returned to the kitchen where he'd caught her peeking at them before, implicating another bright-eyed waitress at her side.

Max said, "I don't know what's got into her."

Cole grunted, forking pancakes in his mouth. They both knew what got into her. It lay between Cole's legs. Jay's legs, too. Their cocks had stirred up his fiancée's hormones and shaken her cart off the track. They were changing her.

"Maybe it's for the better," Cole said, once his mouth was clear.

"I don't know. Maggie can be whatever she wants. I'll be there for her."

"Me, too," Cole said. That stabbed him again. Closer to the heart than when they spoke of her cock-sucking skills. Less enjoyable.

They ate their breakfast under the fawning attention of the waitress. They had more coffee and talked about school. Cole talked about lacrosse and asked if Maggie and he would come to the game in Farmingham next week. He said they would. Mostly they made snide comments about people they didn't like, trying to make each other laugh. When they'd exhausted the roster they began to pick on the Denny's patrons, making up histories for each of them. Stories of long haul trucking and bestiality and meth addiction.

Max said, "And that waitress ...?"

Cole said, "She's cute if she lost a few. Like forty. Nice face."

"Wonder what her oral skills are like."

"I bet they're solid."

"I think she wants to try."

“Go for it.”

Max said, “I meant with you.”

Cole smirked and rolled his eyes. “I’m seeing somebody,” he said, pivoted and signaled for the check.

Cole bought breakfast and left the waitress a ten dollar tip. They drove to the airport and Cole pulled up at the entrance as the sun ascended, turning the sky blue to the west but obscured by tumultuous clouds to the east.

Max got out of the Jeep and stood under the glass canopy, the nighttime lights still buzzing and casting everything in a pale apricot glow. Cole got out as well and came around the other side to stand on the walkway.

Max said, “You don’t need to come in, man. I got it.”

“Right, right. Bring it in,” he said and opened his arms, encouraging Max to hug. He clapped him on the back while they embraced, said, “Say Hi to your folks. Take care. I’ll pick you up on Monday.”

“I told you, don’t skip class. I can take the bus.”

He picked up his bag and threw the strap over a shoulder and Cole pat his arm. Max said, “Take care of Maggie.”

“I will.”

They looked at each other smiling warmly but an awkward slant to the moment. Maybe Cole felt uncomfortable about what that might mean, or that it might not mean what he wanted it to mean. And Max felt a delightful pang of jealousy. He’d decided not to get in their way. Maggie could have her fun and Max would enjoy from the sidelines. When the relationship ended it wouldn’t be Max’s decision. Not if he knew what he was doing.

“Bye, buddy,” he said, nodding and walking backwards. He looked to the east, and as the automatic doors wiped open behind him he said, “Be careful, looks like you’re heading back into a storm.”

Storm

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 21ST

COLE LAY his head on two bunched pillows at the foot of her bed. Legs crossed, feet bare, he held in one hand a glossy paper-bound study guide that said LSAT in purple capital letters. The spine dug into his stomach just above the button of his shorts, the hood of his sweatshirt cowed around his messy blonde hair.

He said, “There’s seven piano students—Tammy, Uli, Vic, Winslow, Xavier, Yannick, and Zoe.”

She said, “Okay.”

“T, U, V, W, X, Y, and Z.”

“I know. I got it.”

“Okay. So the instructor is deciding the order in which they’ll play at an important recital.”

“Uh-huh.”

“They all will play one solo, but of course, each student has restrictions.”

“Typical,” she scoffed. “Fucking pianists.”

His eyes peered at her over the top of the study guide. “Fucking penis?”

“Pi-a-nists,” she giggled and grabbed his big toe. She lay with her head on her pillows, legs also bare, and she wiggled her feet to the side to bat his thigh.

Thunder rumbled outside and a gust of wind sent rain splashing against the windows of her dorm room. Both their heads turned to the grey-green wash outside and watched until the wind settled and the room grew quieter.

Cole continued. "Pi-a-nist. Makes more sense. Okay, Maggie: X can't play first or second, W can't play until X has played, Z has to play seventh, T has to play after Y, and W has to play right after X."

"Whatever."

"Now, the question is: if U plays third, what is the latest position in which Y can play?"

While her eyes darted back and forth over the ceiling, her hand still clutching Cole's foot, her mind put the letters in some semblance. She sorted the possibilities.

"Uh. Sss-six. Yeah, sixth."

He let the study guide drop over his crotch and scowled at her. "You don't even write these down."

"Some of them I would have to. Was that an easy one?"

"Intermediate," he mumbled.

"Give me another one."

"What's the point? You even need to study?"

"Of course I do. You don't want to help me anymore?"

"I do. I do. You're seriously impressive. We've got all day and I'll give you any help you want," he said, bringing the book back up.

"You want to take a break?"

His eyes went up as he thought. He said, "You want to go grab some lunch? Let me buy us a pitcher and a pizza ..."

Rain lashed at the windows again and they both looked to see the sky blurred amid rain driven sideways against the dorm. "I'm not going out in that."

"You don't have an umbrella?"

She laughed at the thought of the two of them trying to huddle under a small Burberry umbrella while the rain came in sideways under it. "Can we order in?"

Cole nodded. "No one delivers beer."

"Mm, it's too wet out. Altieri's for dinner?"

He smiled and nodded, said, "Skip lunch? Work up an appetite?"

She regarded him with a plain expression, a smile tugged at the corner of her mouth but she tugged back. "I told you Max wants me to be good while he's gone."

The LSAT book dropped flat again over his crotch, and he said, "I know. I meant a study appetite."

“Okay, okay,” she cooed. She brought a foot up and lay it on his thigh, rubbed it up and down.

His hand lay on it, warm and welcome. He stroked her from her toes up past her ankle. He said, “Though with Max, I mean, like, what’s ‘good,’ right?”

She gave a breathy chuckle, watched his hand on her ankle.

His eyes watching where he touched her, he said, “You and Max ever talk about having some babies?”

She nodded, said, “You come visit and bounce them on your knee?”

“Can you picture that?”

“Yeah.”

“Then what?”

She shrugged her shoulders into the pillows she lay on, said, “Then what, what?”

“Then Max takes Max Jr. and little Maxine out for ice cream so Cole and mommy can fuck?”

She laughed out loud, a bright guffaw to the ceiling that took her by surprise. She slapped a hand over her mouth, then said, “Hoo, wow. Think so?”

He smirked, ran his hand higher, massaged her calf. “That how we’re going to play this?”

“Just till the wedding, Cole...”

“It’s a long life we get, Maggie. Decades. You’re going to spend decades without your Cole?” He lifted her foot now and gently kissed her toes. She curled them, scrunched his lips and squished them closed.

“Stop it,” she laughed.

“Mm, I can’t be without my Maggie.”

“Your *Margaret*?”

“Oh, you want to play?”

She shook her head no. “Max said I had to be good.”

“You told him this was open.”

“He said be good.”

“Did he say we shouldn’t fuck?”

“No. It’s just ... it’s weird, ‘cause he’s, you know, visiting his parents.”

“So?”

“So, I love his parents. He’s doing family things. I want to be open, but my sweet Maxy ...”

“Aw, I miss my bad Maggie ... sentimental Maggie is—”

“Shit,” she hissed and clapped her hands, jumping off the bed, digging her heel into his thigh before she leaped.

Cole clutched his heart and laughed, “Jesus, Maggie, you scared the shit out of me, what the f—”

“I know, I know,” she babbled, electric current running through her. Drawers were pulled open, sketchpad thrown to the bed, tin of French pastels following closely after. Cole’s eyes followed her movements.

“Let’s take a break,” she said.

“What?”

“I’ve never drawn you.”

“No, you ...” It dawned on him then. He moved himself closer to the edge of the bed, put his feet on the floor. “You mean ...”

“Yeah, I’ve never drawn you. Why have I never ...”

“What do you want?” he asked her.

She smiled and giggled and didn’t need to explain.

Cole stood, and already had the sweatshirt over his head, his arms struggling and elbowing underneath, trying to get it off. “I’m fucking honored, Maggie,” he said under the cotton.

THE PLANE LEFT Albany at 6:45 A.M. yet it was 6:00 A.M. when he arrived at his destination. It was too early to eat again; he was still stuffed from the Denny’s.

From the airport he’d walked to Lindbergh Field then caught a bus that took him into the city. From City College Station it was a short streetcar ride to where he was staying. It was too early to check into the hotel so he walked down to the park that surrounded the marina. Weather was a lot better than chilly Vermont. Seventy and sunny, forecast for eighty. He sat in the park and watched the boats in the bay.

At around 8 A.M., he phoned back east, calling his brother, Connor, who he assumed would have slept off whatever hangover he’d earned on a Friday night at Northwestern.

“What’s up, player?”

Connor groaned, “Who is this?”

“Your liver. I fucked off to Cuba to get some rest, calling to say I’m not coming back.”

“Max?”

“Rise and shine.”

The phone jostled against fabric as his brother rolled over in bed. Connor yawned, grunted, said, “What time is it?”

“I don’t know. Around eleven.”

“What’s up? You okay?”

“Yeah, man. Listen, mom and dad went to Lexington to visit Aunt Amy, right?”

“Yeah. Everything okay?”

“It is. I told Maggie I went home to visit mom and dad, but I didn’t. I’m out west to arrange a surprise for her.”

“Okay ...”

“Yeah, so, should anything come up, should she call looking for me or something, say she couldn’t get a hold of mom and dad or me ...”

“What the fuck are you up to?”

“Just act like you know I went home, okay? Then track me down.”

“Are you going into space or something? Like, why wouldn’t she be able to call you?”

“Relax. She’s not going to call. I just have visions of her calling the house, no one’s there, my phone’s dead or something, she calls you ...”

“And I say mom and pop are in Lexington. Where are you? What’s ‘out west’?”

“San Diego.”

“A surprise for Maggie in San Diego. What is it?”

“It’s a surprise.”

“You are one sneaky motherfucker. Always were.”

“Thanks, Connor.”

He shot the shit with his brother for a while, turned out he had a lady friend in bed with him. When she wanted breakfast Connor said to Max, “Stop harassing me, for fuck’s sake,” then hung up on Max while he was mid-sentence. Abruptly hanging up on each other was always sure to bring a smile to one of the Milton brothers. Not the one hung up on though Max smiled anyway.

At 9 A.M. his stomach was ready for lunch and he went to the Starbucks in the Hilton where he’d booked a room. Afterward he found a space that

rented lockers and he put his heavy peacoat and bag away. When it was 10 A.M. he knew the symposium would be under way so he walked the concourse, heading from the Hilton to the convention center.

Admission was \$45 for students, and they wrapped a pink strap around his wrist. This was the Industrial Biotechnology Expo, a two-day event hosting big players and small players in the emerging Bio-tech business. Pretty much a business/retail convention, but it also attracted keynote speakers in a symposium, hosted in smaller galleries in the outskirts of the show.

Max worked his way through the bustling halls until he was at the north end, dodged right at the impressive and packed CRISPR booth and emerged in a two-story corridor at the foot of dual escalators. Ahead were open double doors, a sign on a chrome stand out front told him this was the gallery he searched for.

He slipped into the nearly packed room and took a seat at the back row, on the aisle. As late-comers arrived, and attendees got themselves comfortable, Max scanned the room. A third of the way from the podium, almost dead center, he saw a young man with the right hairstyle. He wore a white Oxford button-down and sat next to another young serious-looking Asian male. When the guy in the white Oxford turned he saw that it was indeed Ken, Maggie's brother.

The lights dimmed, and a spotlight was turned on above the podium. A guy in a suit with an event badge swinging on a lanyard came to center stage and announced the speaker. A casually dressed middle-aged Chinese man took his place at the podium. The room went quiet and the 'talk' began.

Dr. Yingxu Peng-Sheng from the National Sun Yat-sen University in Taiwan was the speaker. Something about the use of electrons and laser beams in bio applications. Max hung with it for a while but it got esoteric fast and it wasn't long before his eyes began to flutter. Up all night with Maggie, awake at four in the morning, a massive greasy breakfast, a flight, a listless morning, all conspired to take him down. He dozed.

SKETCHBOOK ON KNEES, feet on bed, smirk on face, she watched Cole get naked. This was the first time she'd seen him naked like this in such a

plain matter. Usually their times together were hot trysts, rich with forbidden lust; when they undressed Cole was erect, and she had dampened her panties—when she wore them.

Now she watched this amazing boy in her life lit with even, gray light that fell into her room warbled with sheets of rain beating on the glass behind her. Trim, fit, beautiful skin; his hips were narrow, his stomach lean, his ass perfect and round, pale against the summer tan he still held though was beginning to fade. He turned, and she saw him fully exposed.

The slightest look of apprehension tensed his features. Like he looked for her approval, worried about it. There was nothing to be ashamed of. She loved his penis. It was big, but unaroused it wasn't so intimidating. Cole was a grower. That look in his eyes as he watched her expression as she took his bare body in, lit with bright undramatic gray, he exposed to her a tiny sliver of vulnerability. It swelled her heart in her chest and she felt fathomless warmth for her lover and best friend.

An unstoppable smile pulled her lips wide, and she felt suddenly embarrassed and hid her face behind her sketchbook, an uncontrollable giggle wriggling up through her and making her shake.

"Lost your nerve," he said, "afraid you'll never capture this male perfection?"

She sat up straighter, ran her hair back, pencil poised between two fingers of her right hand. She looked in his eyes and said, "You are absolutely beautiful."

"Jesus, Maggie," he said, flinching at her words. "I expected a joke, not something so ..."

"Honest?"

"Well, shit, how you want this beautiful body posed?"

"Be creative."

"I should probably do some push-ups or something first, get a pump going ..."

"Just pick a pose, already."

"It's going to take a while, so I'll sit."

"That's perfect."

As he got a knee on the bed, she stopped him.

"Hold on."

"What?"

"I've never seen your penis soft before."

“That’s your fault.”

“Let me see it.”

“Up close?”

“Let me see it.” She leaned her elbows on her knees, chest pressing her sketchbook against her thighs and watched Cole walk closer on his knees. He smirked, looking down as she darted her eyes to his. She smiled sheepishly.

He said, “Go on and look. I don’t mind. It’s not going to be soft for long.”

“I can’t draw erections. Long story.”

“You get in trouble already? ... been drawing hard-ons, you little perv?”

Moving her eyes back to his fat hanging penis, she said, “Let’s try to keep this classy.”

“You might have picked the wrong model.”

“You’re the right model.”

He presented it to her boldly, his hands resting on his hip bones, that vulnerability gone and her confident Cole returned. She examined him. Completely flaccid, it hung lower than his scrotum, foreskin hiding the end of it, his balls large and oblong. They were bigger than Jay’s, bigger than Max’s. She dipped her head to the right, cocked it so she could peek into the foreskin but saw nothing, just the ruffled pink folds. She sat back straight again, and he said, “Okay?”

She nodded and gave him a funny smile, said, “I like it.”

He laughed, said, “Well, that’s good,” and let himself fall back on her bed, his rump bouncing until he sat at the footboard, his genitals slapping between his legs. He fluffed some pillows and put them behind his back, put an elbow up on the curved rail of the footboard, moved his shoulders around so he rested against it. “How’s that? Can I put my elbow up on here?”

“You can do whatever you want.”

“Does it show off my abs?”

“I can’t see your abs,” she laughed

He looked down and ran his other hand over his tight midsection, his chin down to his chest. He grunted, “No, you can’t—I should’ve dieted if I knew you were going to do this.”

“You’re so vain.”

“What? If my girl is going to capture me for posterity I want to be at my best.”

She worked the pencil over the paper without touching, just her fingertips exploring all the space, preparing herself for what she would do. She said, “I want to draw you how I know you.”

Cole’s eyes grew sultry while his mouth still smirked with confidence. His hand fell between his legs and held his penis, manipulated it.

“What are you doing?”

Cole said, “Making myself how you know me.”

She lowered her eyes, broke the spell cast by watching his penis in his own hand. “I’d like to start drawing, please.”

“Okay,” he said, his hand coming away and resting on the mattress now. She began to draw, her fingers bringing the pencil closer to the paper and lightly declaring positive and negative space. The space where Cole would exist and not exist on her paper. Her eyes moved steadily from subject to paper and back again.

His penis buckled. She stopped. Cole was expressionless, and she smirked. His penis extended slowly, lengthening, rising to tap along the inside of his tanned thigh. He held her gaze and shrugged, showing her his arousal was inevitable. That maddening smirk of his returned again, stormy light sparkled in his narrowed eyes.

It brought a strange dread that chilled her stomach. Memories of Jay rising up inside. That boy she fucked, or rather, let fuck her, because she was inexperienced. She’d had no feelings for Jay, only a carnal curiosity. She’d wanted that so bad, wanted to know what it would be like to sleep with him. And her Max allowed it. Now, with Cole in her life, loving her and supporting her just as Max did, those moments with Jay seemed so strange and dark. Jay seemed like a stranger now, and in a way she regretted sleeping with him. Their times together amounted to a one-night-stand, and while that experience was something she’d wanted, now having it, she regretted it.

And here, before her, came the same experience that had launched that affair. A figure model who just couldn’t keep his beautiful penis from growing under her gaze. It was a compliment. She’d drawn in groups before, had plenty of male models (none anywhere as exciting as Jay or Cole), and no one had grown aroused before. Sure there had been movement, a lurching to the left or right, testicles that sagged and climbed,

but it wasn't until she was one-on-one that her men let their genitals get away from them. They wanted her to see their arousal. They were proud of their arousal. It made her pulse race. Knowing that her eyes on their bodies were enough to spark a full erection made her powerful and feminine. The intimacy of this situation, pretty girl, handsome boy, provoked something inevitable. This was biological finality. Two apex predators. If Cole and Jay grew to hardness in her simple presence that meant she was one of them. Maggie Becker was in their league.

As she drew, Cole's penis continued gaining hardness. Her hand continued making light shapes on the paper and her eyes watched what happened between his legs. His penis lengthened, bobbed along his leg, eventually began to pull away from that support to stand on its own, though it bowed heavily. Then it lurched, swung quickly to the side like a door on a hinge until it tapped against the opposite thigh. Cole's belly heaved as he laughed. "Sorry," he said.

It bobbed and rose, first heading right her way, that blind ruffled end poking straight at her, then arcing, curving its back like it was doing yoga. Then up and up again, and it ended up on his belly pointing to his chest.

"It was inevitable," Cole said, still holding her gaze with that sultry stare she couldn't wait to put down on paper. It *was* inevitable. Just with Jay, even more so with Cole. "Draw it hard."

She huffed with a small laugh, eyes on her paper. "Draw it hard?"

"Yeah, draw me like this."

She giggled, eyes averted. "What'll I do with that?"

"Do it. That's how I want people to see me anyway, Maggie. Hang it up here," he said, nodding to the wall next to her bed with his chin. "God, Max would love that."

The pencil traced around the page, getting a feel for the space. "He would, I think."

"It's not going to stop now, Maggie. I can't get it to go down. Draw it like it is."

"Okay," she agreed quietly. "This one will be for me."

"Fuck, that's hot."

She stopped again, regarded him. She sat on her dorm room bed, alone with her friend and lover, feeling so warm and happy and safe, sequestered with him, a storm lashing at the windows. Wearing a cozy sweatshirt, comfy sweatpants, no socks, there was a constant excitement when she felt her

bare foot touch Cole. Now she extended her legs, lay them flat on the bed, her sketchbook across her thighs. She slumped, let her back come down her pillows. A foot extended, her left, reaching out and her toes and the pads touched the belly of Cole's cock. He stayed in his pose, watching her and she tried not to burst out laughing. It was easy because while she wanted to, her whole insides had been twisted up tight and hard.

Cole was a grower indeed, his cock now hot and wide and hard, almost as far across as her foot. With her toes she angled his erection, so it went up on an angle. She scrunched her toes just the slightest, pulling back his foreskin. Then her foot came away.

"What are you doing?"

She said, "I'm angling it," her eyes on his manhood, surmising it like a serious artist would. It ticked like a minute hand, one click with each heartbeat, until it pointed straight up once more, letting her know it was twelve o'clock. She moved it again with her toes, felt the springy tension in it, his intense hardness shortening her breath and clouding her mind. As her foot came away, it slid right back pointing north.

"It won't angle," she whispered.

"No," he agreed.

She bit her lip and shimmied herself up to the pillows again and raised her knees. "I wanted to draw your belly button, but your penis is in the way."

"You like my belly button?"

"It's cute. It has a certain fuzzy charm."

"I like your belly button."

"Yours is cuter."

"I beg to differ."

She lowered her knees until the light shone on her page the way she liked and she stared at the pastel shapes that would become her lover.

She said, "Yeah, mine is pretty cute."

Her eyes returned to him, found him staring back into hers with overwhelming confidence. One arm up, draped over her footboard behind him, chin tucked, sexy eyes lowered to her gaze, beautiful lean and tanned body presented to her, a frighteningly thick erection jutting up between his legs; her tummy fluttered, and she had to look away, eyes down to her drawing.

Cole said, "This is probably a bad idea."

“Why?”

“Tell me we’re not going to be fucking in half an hour.”

“We’re not going to be fucking in half an hour. I have self-control, Cole.”

“Whatever. There’s no reason we c—”

“Shh-sh,” she shushed him. “I can’t draw your mouth when it’s moving.”

He laughed. “Such a bitch,” he murmured, making her smile and run her tongue out at him while her hand sketched his beauty onto the toothy paper.

Grande

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 21ST

MAX AWOKED with the sound of his name. When his eyes opened, he saw that the gallery lights were on. The talk was over, or at least on a break, and the attendees were standing, some talking, some filing up the aisle to exit out the main doors. Dr. Yingxu Peng-Sheng gathered papers at the podium.

Max darted his chin forward and looked around. Ken stood over him, hand on his chest, tapping him, saying, “Max, what are you doing here?”

He had trouble waking, trouble moving his mouth, a heavy torpor weighing on him, sleep trying to claw him back to its world. He had slumped in his seat and he dug his elbows in the armrests and lifted himself higher.

“Ken,” he said, “Hey, Ken. I came here to see you.”

At Ken’s elbow the other student he’d sat with loitered, hands in pocket, blankly surmising Max. The two of them stood in the aisle, Ken bent over with a hand resting on Max’s shoulder now.

“Came to see me?”

“Yeah, I was in San Diego, and I saw your Instagram.”

Ken stood and turned to his friend, said, “This is Max. He’s marrying my sister.” Then to Max, “Max, this is Brian. He’s at Stanford with me, in the program.”

Max stood up and rubbed his cheeks, tucked in his shirt. After they shook hands, Max said to Ken, “Well, I thought since I was here, I could come and talk to you ...”

Ken’s face was expressionless but his brow lowered. “What about?”

Max could tell that he already knew what it was about. There was something between them that needed to be discussed. Up to this point it was safe to assume that Ken hadn't wanted it to be discussed. Max said, "I don't know," and held Ken's gaze.

Ken said, "Brian and I are on our way to lunch."

Max said, "Sorry, maybe I could just get you a coffee. Ten minutes."

Ken turned to his friend Brian, they looked at each other strangely, a conversation passing in their eyes, then without speaking a word to Brian, Ken said to Max, "Okay. Ten minutes. But we have to eat, Brian and I, and we want to go to the CRISPR talk at one o'clock."

Max said, "Ten minutes."

"SO I HEAR you and Max were very busy last night."

Max must have been bragging on their car ride this morning. They indeed had an epic evening of debauchery. "We were busy all night long."

"Aw, you and my little buddy?"

"It was nice," she said. Her hand worked with energy, white pastel putting the finishing touches on a drawing of Cole. The white put the highlights on, gave his body a slippery electric charge. Much like what she felt when she drew him.

This was the fastest she'd ever drawn. Her heart beating frenziedly in accompaniment as she grew excited to finish her work, wanting to see the final product, wanting to commit to paper the incredible sight that she recorded with her eyes. The only sound in the room had been the pastels on the paper. In her ears however had been the most pressing drumbeat. A swoosh-swoosh of her furious little heart. Cole was so incredibly handsome, and it tingled her fingertips to press pencil point to paper and bring what she saw to life in her own realistic but somehow lurid, sweaty style.

She exhaled quietly, wishing her heart rate down, excitement quivering her arms. She was done, and this drawing was special. The way she saw him was captured.

"Okay," she said, her effort to whisper while so overridden with a strange lust, squeezing her throat and making her utterance inaudible.

“Did you say okay?”

She nodded, feeling her cheeks blush.

“I can move?”

She nodded again.

Cole exhaled now, brought his arm from the footboard, and stretched his back, favoring his stiff shoulder. “Can I see?”

“Yeah,” she said, throwing her white pastel into a tin and closing the lid. She chewed her bottom lip in strange anticipation. Moved her drawing tools aside and got to her knees, the sketchpad clutched to her chest.

“Show me,” he said with odd seriousness, looking in her eyes.

“I will,” she said, walking to him on the mattress, seeing him open an arm up, inviting her to lay with him. He was naked and sexy, his arousal throbbing and prominent. She lay with him. Put herself against his side, let him fold his arm around her shoulder and cradle her.

Slowly, she revealed her drawing to him, letting the pad curl away from her. Her eyes on his, knowing already what was there and wanting only to see his reaction. His head shook, chin darted to his chest, he was taken aback. She knew. It was a good one.

“Oh my God,” he whispered, just as inaudible as she had been. He moved a hand to cover his mouth.

She smirked, then bit her smile, swallowed it up in nervousness. Cole’s eyes grew wet, and they glistened in the storm’s light.

“Holy shit, Maggie. You are so incredible.”

The drawing was disgusting, lurid. Something that would have to be hidden, never shown to another person. She showed Cole how she saw him. Dominant sex personified. Jay had been made oily and atavistic. Cole was just as sleazy, just as lubricious, but she’d captured something else there; the love of friendship, his kindness, his knowledge of her, his ability to dominate her and not frighten her, his enormous capacity as a true friend. Her own eyes began to tear. She pulled the drawing close again.

“Wow, Maggie,” he said, and he held her, clutched her to his chest and lay his chin on her head and she closed her eyes and felt his warm loving body. “There’s nothing you can’t do, is there?” he whispered.

She sat up as he lay the pad on his thighs. “What do you mean?”

“I can’t wait to see all the things you accomplish.”

She huffed, smirked, let her eyes lower to his lips.

They were so close together she could feel his breath on the sensitive skin of her neck. A few nights ago they'd been intimate. With Max, together they had a threesome, too, a few nights before. Abstinence was an artificial construct. They came together slowly, Cole's eyes lowering as well now.

At the last possible moment, even past the point where she thought she would succumb, her tummy crunched quick and fast, thrusting her expected kiss downward. Her pouted lips mashed into the rigid head of his cock and she made a cartoon kiss sound as she tried to scramble away. Flopped belly first on the mattress, legs kicking to get herself away from him, she burst out laughing as his hands struggled to hold her ankles.

"Get back here," he laughed.

He slapped at her ankles as she pretended to kick at him, crawling like an alligator on her elbows and knees back to her end of the bed. Cole remained in his half, sitting upright and forward now, muscular arms planted in the bed, gaze lowed in mirthful menace. She flipped over onto her back and raised a foot like she would strike him with a heel.

He said, "You're such a brat."

"You love it when I'm playful."

They stared each other down, her leg poised like a scorpion's tail and him ready to scramble over top of her and subdue her.

"I really do."

Her hand covered her mouth, and she said, "Ow, I hurt my lips."

"Serves you right."

"My teeth are throbbing."

"How you going to explain this to your dentist?"

"My boyfriend's cock was a lot harder than I expected."

"You ought to know it by now."

"I should," she said. Then, "Stay down there," and she indicated to the footboard with her pointed toes.

"I should probably put this beautiful dick away ... you can't keep your mouth off it ..."

"That's up to you," she laughed.

Cole pivoted and got off the bed, slipped his shorts on, handled his arousal through the cotton, let her watch him, groaned. She put her foot down and enjoyed watching him dress. When he had his sweatshirt on he threw himself at the opposite end, making the bed bounce, crossing one leg over the other. She pet his foot.

He watched her silently for a while and she crossed her hands in her lap and began to feel awkward. “What?” she laughed finally and ran her hair back on both sides, tucking it behind her ears.

“You’re perfect,” he said. In his hand, pulled from his sweatshirt pouch was his iPhone, he flipped it so he could read it and she waited. He snapped a picture of her.

“Hey, don’t,” she said, putting her hands up to block her face from him. “Why did you do that?”

He was looking at his phone now, said, “I can’t draw, but I want to remember how you look right now.”

She let her hands droop, watched as he regarded the picture, his thumb still moving. “What are you doing now?”

“Sending it to Max,” he said.

“Cole ...? What the hell?” she said, scrambling over to his side. “You did not ... Let me see.”

He hid his phone from her and put an arm up to block her. She punched his shoulder and slapped his chest playfully. “You better not have.”

He smiled. “Oh, I did.”

“Cole, I’m serious.”

“Uh-oh.”

She scrunched her face up and scrutinized him, narrowing her eyes to slits. There was no way he did.

Now he showed her the phone, and she peeked closer. “Oh, my God. You really sent it.”

“I told you ...”

On the screen she saw a miniaturized version of the picture he’d taken. Her sitting against the pillows in a sweatshirt and short sweatpants, her calves and feet bare. She held her hair back from her face and looked confused. Underneath Cole had written:

Cole: just helping this smart girl study for her LSAT

That wasn’t that bad. But it punched her with guilt. It didn’t divulge the dirty intimate act they’d just partaken. Drawing him had been astoundingly intimate and while it didn’t show in the picture, she read it in the eyes of the girl in the photo, and maybe Max could too.

“Give me,” she said and held a hand out for his phone. He handed it over.

She typed:

Cole: It's me, baby. I was posing for you

She sent it, grimaced at how contrite her message was, but it made her feel marginally better. She tossed his phone to the bed and lay back on her pillow. “Why would you send that?”

Cole shrugged his shoulders and watched his hands laying on his stomach. “I’m feeling Max out.”

“For what?”

Now he looked at her. “You know.”

She said, “Don’t. It’s me. I’m saying I want to cool it while he’s gone.”

“We do it all the time. What does it mean if we do it now?”

“What does it mean if I say I won’t and then I do? Don’t I have any resolve? ... Any respect for my relationship with Max? ...”

“Do you?”

“I do.”

“We’re open.”

“I know.”

“How can you have an open relationship with someone you’re going to marry?”

“It’s with you.”

“I’m special?”

“Yeah, you are,” she said, cocking her head and smiling.

He took her ankle and his thumb ran along the arch of her foot, running an excited line up the back of her neck. “So, let’s just do it.”

“No, Cole. I said I wouldn’t. I feel funny. He’s with his mom and dad.”

THERE WAS a Starbucks at the end of the hall on the floor that they were on, but when they arrived, the lineup was too long.

Ken said, “Follow me, I know where we can get a coffee.” They turned around and headed back the way they came. Ahead of them was Brian,

who'd been following along about thirty paces behind while Ken and Max walked awkwardly, not speaking. Brian stood with his hands in his pockets as they got closer, Ken shrugged and nodded to him and Brian waited for them to pass. Ken and Max resumed, heading to the other end of the concourse and Brian followed at a safe distance behind.

"It's just down here," Ken said as they walked down the moving steps of an escalator heading to the floor below.

Two floors down they ended up at the subway level, still in the convention center. Ken led him into what looked like a diner or some sort of variety store. It had the trimmings of a gas station 7-11. Ductwork ran above through steel girders, and the floors were chipped beige tile. Still not talking, they passed between rows of Doritos and potato chips neatly stacked in wire racks, made their way to a line of two people in the middle of the left-hand side of the store at a narrow counter. A menu board spelled out in black plastic letters all their deli items.

Max grabbed a Clif Bar while they waited. They ordered three coffees and Max paid. Heading back out he handed the third coffee to Brian who lingered in the doorway to the convention center. Ken waved for Max to follow him again and they wove through passing people and settled under the triangular slope of an overhead escalator. It was quiet here, and they were alone, the people passed by a few arm's length away in the concourse. Brian sat and drank his coffee on a bench outside the diner.

Ken sipped his coffee, said, "So you are really out here in San Diego for school?"

Max said, "Yeah, I had to come out here for a school thing," wanting to move quickly into the conversation he came for but feeling anxious now. Ken was less receptive than he had feared.

Ken sipped again, said, "How's Maggie?"

"She's doing great," Max said. He played with the plastic tab on the lid of his coffee. "You want to sit down?"

There were no chairs, so they both sat cross-legged on the carpeted floor, Max underneath the drooping fronds of a potted palm. Max said, "You know she wants to get into law school now?"

Ken said, "Yeah, I know."

"She talked to you?"

"No, Martin told me."

Max nodded, took a swig of decent coffee. "Yeah, I was surprised, too."

“I wasn’t so surprised,” Ken said.

“You weren’t?”

“Not really.”

“Well, I was surprised,” Max said. “How’s school?”

“Me? It’s great, Max. I’m studying what I’ve always wanted.” He held his coffee away and made an elaborate gesture to check the clock face on his iPhone. Max watched him, flipping his own phone over and over in his free hand. Ken said, “You know, Max. I really do have to get going. You want to meet tomorrow?”

Max said, “No, I don’t want to take up your time. It’s just ... Okay ...” He set his coffee down on the floor, preparing a strategy in his head. His phone buzzed in his grip. It was a perfect distraction, and he turned it to face him. On the screen he saw a picture of Maggie. She was sitting on her bed which he knew very well—it was where he left her this morning. The light was stormy and gray, somewhere over her shoulder on the right-hand side. She was beautiful, holding her hair back from her face, a tense look of disquiet frozen on her beautiful features. She wore a baggy sweatshirt, shorts, her legs were bare. The text was from Cole. His stomach bounced as if he had been struck. Below the picture, it read:

Cole: just helping this smart girl study for her LSAT

He sighed and inhaled while Ken watched him furtively.

“Something up?” he said.

Under Cole’s text there was another message. Though it said it was from Cole, he was sure it was from Maggie; it read: *It’s me, baby. I was posing for you.* Maggie taking the phone away from Cole to soothe her fiancé’s feelings. His posture slumped.

To Ken he said, “Just the reason I came all this way.”

Convention

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 21ST

AFTER A LONG STATEMENT regarding a fictional government's stance on product labeling, Cole said, "So young Margaret, after considering the government's preceding statement, which of the following is most strongly suggested ... a) a warning that applies to a small population is inappropriate, b) very few p—"

Maggie said, "You and Max never ... what we did ... you guys never did that with ... some girl ..."

He set the LSAT guide down on his lap. "What? Me and Max—double-team a girl?"

"Double team?" she said, her brows tilting up high and forlorn.

"Oh, no way, Maggie. Max isn't like that. You know Max. I've never done that before."

"You haven't?"

"Not two dudes. I've been with two girls."

"Really?"

He nodded like it wasn't a big deal. "Bunch of times."

She crossed her legs with petulance and clasped her hands on her tummy, looked away from him and up at the wall. "Gross. I hate to think of you with them."

"It wasn't love, Maggie. It was just bodies."

"I hate to think of your thing," she said, putting a foot out and tapping near his crotch, "going in their things."

"Don't think about it. I don't."

"You don't?"

“Maggie, I couldn’t even tell you their names.”

“I don’t know if that’s better or worse.”

“Yeah, you do.”

“Yeah, I do,” she agreed.

He let her stew on that a while, and she wouldn’t look at him, her gaze instead traveling around her room. Cole had been with a lot of girls. There were probably a lot of things he’d done that she didn’t want to know about. Her own sexual experimentation had come late, and strangely, Cole had been a very big part of it. She’d been with multiple partners, she’d gone crazy with her Max and let him watch her with another man. There were other things still she wouldn’t mind trying. But somehow she was stuck on this set of men. Her good friends. Her fiancé and the Best Man. Two guys in her life that she trusted and loved and cared fully for. The idea of experimentation, while still glimmering, seemed to wane and grow distant. But the wedding date was getting closer with each heartbeat.

She looked at him now, and he was waiting for her, smiling and listening. She said, “Do you think you could both go in at the same time?”

“With you? We did that.”

“No ...”

“Yes, we did, Maggie. Or wait,” he paused, cocking his head and looking up like he was trying to recollect. To himself he muttered, “Maybe Max and I did that with a different girl.”

She opened her mouth wide and frowned in mock astonished horror. “Fuck off,” she enunciated slowly, then sat up and punched his thigh.

“Ha ha, no, I remember. It was you. It was you in your music room.”

“You’re damn right that was me in my music room,” she said getting up on all fours and crawling near him, looking in his eyes, hers narrowed slyly.

“How could I forget?” he whispered.

“Right. I mean both in the same time, same ...”

“We did ...”

“No, the same ...” She put her hand between her thighs.

“What?” he laughed. “Hole? At the same time?”

“Yeah. No?”

He stared at her, his eyes darting over hers, a trembling open-mouthed smile on his face, a creak in his throat as he tried to find the right words.

She repeated, “What? No?”

He laughed out loud, leaned close and put his lips on hers. Her arms went around him, wrapped his neck and she kissed him with an open mouth, her tongue going over his. When he withdrew he said, "God, Maggie, I'm so glad to have you in my life."

"What, cause I want two at once? ..."

"It's the way you want it. You're the sweetest thing."

His lips took hers again, presumptively, and she pushed him away.

He said, "Let me kiss you one more time. I swear I'll stop at one."

"That would be two. We can stop at two?"

"I know we can. Kiss me."

"One kiss, Cole."

Putting a limit on it was exciting. Their whole relationship was based on limits and exceeding them. It was in the excess that she found the ecstasy.

So when their lips came together she focused on the hesitation, focused on the tightness around her neck like she was a dog pulling on its lead. Their kiss was sweet and completely PG, soft pressing, breathing against one another.

They kept it at one more kiss. Long and protracted and sweet. Literally sweet. When she pulled back, eyes on his, she softly said, "You taste like maple syrup."

He bit that sexy, plump lower lip and eyed her. He gave her a smile, said, "Me and Maxy had pancakes."

"You did? Now I wish I got out of bed to go."

"Why didn't you?"

"Tired," she said, stretching one arm up over her head. She scooted to the head of the bed and lay her back against the pillows. "Late nights. I just doubled my load taking on these LSATs."

"You brought that on yourself."

"I know I did."

"You just need me so bad you gotta follow me all the way to Harvard like a little puppy dog."

She laughed, but it was constricted. She said, "There's other schools I could go to. I'm not applying only to Harvard."

His eyes met hers and slowly his smile faded seeing she wasn't joking. "Don't," he said, his brow lowered.

She smiled warmly, said, “Who’s the puppy dog now?”

MAX TOOK A DEEP BREATH, said, “Well, let’s start at the very worst point.”

Ken said, “Okay,” and he put his coffee down on the floor as well.

Max said, “God, this is so hard,” and he rolled his head around on his neck. Ken’s eyes darted to the time on his phone again. Max said, “Okay, okay, I can guess you know why I’m here, and probably understand why this is so hard. So I’m going to jump right in: you saw us in the music room.”

As Max had started the sentence, Ken’s eyes drifted downward, not at his phone this time, down at the design on the carpet. This was not something he wanted to talk about. Neither did Max, but he was going to marry this man’s sister.

Ken said, “You know I did.”

“I know you did.”

Ken still wouldn’t look up. He said, “I saw you. I saw my sister. And Cole.”

Max said, “I’m sorry you had to see that. Don’t say anything, I don’t want to make this hard for you. I just want it to be addressed.”

“You don’t have to—”

“I really do have to, Ken. You can see that I have to.”

Ken shrugged his shoulders almost imperceptibly.

Max said, “I really am sorry that you saw that. I guess ... I guess you should know ... I want you to know that Maggie is okay. You know, I care about her.”

“Of course ...”

“Right, of course I care about her. I just don’t want you to think ... I don’t want you to think that I made her do something she didn’t want to do.”

“I tried not to think about it at all.”

“Right, that makes sense. But still, it weighs on me, that you might think that I’m bad for Maggie.”

“I hadn’t thought about it.”

“Well, okay, I just ... I just think that you should know, it wasn’t even my idea.”

“You came all this way to tell me what I saw was my sister’s fault?”

“No, I came all this way tell you that she’s happy. I might not be happy, but she’s very happy.”

“You’re not happy?”

“With what you saw? No. I don’t know how much I can tell you, or should tell you, but Maggie ... wants more experience ...”

“Don’t tell me ...”

“No, but I want you to know that I want what’s best for her and now I’m not sure if I’m doing the right thing.”

Ken shook his head, and looked up at the sloping ceiling above them, half-smiling lips probably trying to form the phrase: *Stop talking*.

But he wouldn’t stop talking, he came here for a reason.

“I think Maggie needs help,” he said with finality as if this was the point he was coming to.

“Help with what?”

“I gave her freedom, and she’s taking more than I bargained for. I think Cole is taking advantage.”

“How?”

“Look, we don’t have much time, I know, so let me say: I came for your help.”

“What do you think I can do?”

“You can give me the security footage.”

Ken said, “What security footage?”

WHILE MAGGIE STRUGGLED to reach her phone, Cole tugged on her ankles and kept her from getting to it. She kicked her legs lightly, putting up the appearance of struggle, and swam on the surface of her bed, one arm extending to the nightstand where her phone vibrated underneath her flea-market lamp.

“Cole!” she laughed.

“We were talking,” he said, yanking her further away.

She laughed and struggled to pull her sweatshirt down from where it rode up at her waist.

Cole said, "We have things to discuss, Margaret."

"I have to get it," she giggled. "Cole, I have to. What if it's Max?"

He released her, the phone now in its fourth ring. He ran his hands up her calves but she got to her knees and retrieved the phone. She flipped it over and looked at the screen and saw who was calling. She said, "Ugh," and turned it to face Cole, showing him the screen of her phone, saying, "Speaking of 'Margaret.'" On her screen the word Carol floated over a picture of her mother, an executive portrait where she wore a crisp suit and a stern face.

Cole smiled and lay back, humming Flight of the Valkyries.

Maggie, still upright on her knees, answered, said, "Hello?"

It was like walking in on a conversation midway. After a curt, "Margaret," a confirmation she had on the phone the person she intended, Carol was right into business, leaving Maggie wondering why she answered when she could have easily stayed play wrestling on the bed with Cole.

"Your father and I have been spending time on the paperwork needed for your applications."

"Yes," she said, feeling a bureaucratic entanglement settling on her and robbing her of the fun she was having. She settled down to sit on her heels now.

Carol continued. "You understand the effort required to attend?"

"Of course."

"I mean your obligations, Margaret."

"Yes, of course I do."

"You have too much going on, Margaret. We worry about your focus."

"My focus?" she said, exasperated, rolling her eyes for Cole who watched her intently. "I'm studying for the LSAT right now. I'm confident I will be accepted."

"I'm confident you will as well."

"You are?" she said, hating the automatic bolstering she felt, a lifetime of conditioning in the Becker household pumping chemicals of acceptance and appreciation into her bloodstream.

"Margaret, you're capable of much more than even Law School."

"I am? Like what?"

“Listen, Margaret, have you considered you would be married when you attend?”

“I know,” she said weakly, that endorphin rush quelled by sudden dread.

“What does Max say about this?”

“I don’t know.”

“You don’t know? Would he be opposed to postponing the wedding?”

“Max? No. I don’t know. I don’t want to, I—”

“Would you and Max visit next weekend?”

“Why would we postpone the wedding?”

Cole’s jaw dropped, and he made a *Holy Shit!* face, scooting closer to her and resting his hand on her knee. She felt her posture slump, the effort of staying upright a chore now and she fell back to sit in her pillows, Cole stroking her foot and watching her expression with concern. But Cole kept his expression bright, and he mouthed, *Don’t worry*, and the warmth from this made her feel so good inside.

“Your father and I would like to meet you and Max next weekend.”

“Okay,” she said, hating her phone and the fact that she could be reached. “I can be at Law School and married. I have no doubt.”

Cole scooted closer, his thumb on her foot coming close to tickling her and she flinched. He did it again, making her jump, and she made a mean face to him, mouthed *Stop*, but she had to cover her mouth to stop her mother from hearing her mirth.

“Is something funny, Margaret?”

“No,” she said, a tremble in her face as she took her foot out of Cole’s grip while he winked at her. “I’m going to Law School and I *will* be married.”

“If that’s what you want, but you should consider what it may do to your school year. Harvard isn’t easy. And you’re not going unless you’re top in your class.”

Those words put a sick dread in her stomach like she was back in high school, and insurmountable pressure was on. Somehow the idea of marrying Max—being out of the Becker household, maybe working at a gallery dabbling at painting while Max earned a living, which he would certainly do, grew more appealing. And she hated that her mother had made Max that escape, mad that Carol had made Max something that was easy to settle for. The truth was he *was* easy to settle for. Marrying Max would be

like slipping on a water slide, rushing along an easy groove, something with no friction. It was a terrible thought.

She said, "I'll think about it," though she knew she wouldn't.

Carol said, "You should talk to Max. Come next weekend, and I'd like you to bring Cole as well."

"Okay, mother, I have to go, my study partner just arrived. We have a lot to do," she said and got to her knees again, ran her nails through Cole's hair just above his ear and he leaned his head to her touch. They said their curt goodbyes, and she tossed her phone to the bed and groaned.

"Bad?" Cole asked as she collapsed theatrically into his arms.

"Next time I try to answer my phone I need you to fight harder to stop me."

"Deal," he said. "You okay?"

"I'm fine but I want to have fun right now. I don't want to study any more."

"But Margaret, your study partner just got here," he laughed and held her.

Valkyries

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 21ST

MAX SAID, "ARE YOU KIDDING?"

Ken said, "No, I'm not kidding, Max, just tell me what you're talking about."

"Your house has security cameras—"

"It does?"

"—that caught what we did."

Ken sighed, turned his palms up and shook his head, facing difficulty expressing what he wanted to say. "Max, I don't know what to tell you. I don't know anything about it."

"You didn't do anything ... didn't erase the security camera ... the footage?"

"Listen, I'm not surprised Martin has a security system, I just don't know the first thing about it. That can't surprise you."

"No," he agreed.

"Why do you think there's a recording?"

He stared at the floor, lost in bewildered thought. "I know there is."

Ken sipped his coffee, turned his phone to check the time. "How come Maggie isn't here asking me for this?"

"She doesn't know you saw us."

Ken raised his eyebrows and nodded. "Really."

"I didn't tell her."

"What did you want to do with this security footage I was supposed to give you? Show her?"

He nodded, and Ken frowned and shook his head in admonishment. “What?” Max said.

“Max, I love my sister. She can do what she wants. You know what she’s like, you know how smart she is, she’s a smart person. Whatever it is she wants to do I’m fine with it. I don’t want to know about it. And I didn’t like what I saw. But I’m not one to judge. What I don’t like is subterfuge.”

“I wanted it to help her.”

“Show her what she looked like? Show her as I saw her?”

“Not like that.”

“What you’re telling me, Max, I don’t believe. Maggie wouldn’t force you into that ... what I saw. I saw what I saw with my own eyes, you were laughing, enjoying it. Until you saw me. I don’t know what it is you’re up to, but you could probably leave me out of it. That would be for the best.”

It hurt, and he felt rejected. But he’d prepared for this. “I’m worried about what’s happening to her, that she’s being led somewhere dark. She’s changing ...”

“Max, where we came from, the way we were raised, it will take a lot for us to figure out who we are. It’s not easy for me and I don’t talk to Maggie about it, but I imagine it’ll be hard for her too. She doesn’t know who she is. Maybe she’s just finding out. We were raised like computer programs, Max. Now we’re AI, out in the real world, trying to mate who we are inside with reality.”

“I want that, too, Ken. Look, maybe the truth is I wanted it. Maybe I wanted her to find out who she is—”

“Now you don’t like who she is?”

He shook his head and set his coffee cup down on the floor, rubbed his hands through his hair. Never had he anticipated such antagonism from Ken. Saw this going a lot smoother. Even the truth now seemed like arrows launched at a castle wall. All his resolve, all his craft now being eroded by a dreadful realization that someone had probably seen the three of them together on video and he had no idea who.

COLE SAID, “So, what did Carol want?”

“Carol? First name basis?”

“Carol and I go way back.”

“What was she like back in the good old days?”

Cole laughed, said, “She was a lot like you.”

“I’ll bet,” Maggie said. “Just wedding stuff. She hadn’t bugged me in a while, figured I was due.”

“She worries.”

She regarded Cole at the foot of the bed, sitting with his legs up, watching her, warbling shadows on his face from the sheets of rain that quivered down her windows.

He eyed her speculatively. Then he said, “We email.”

“Who emails?”

“Carol and I,” he said, barely containing the humor this was giving him.

“You and Carol?” she exclaimed.

“Sure, we keep in touch.”

“Fuck off.”

“We like to plot Maggie’s path.”

“You do not,” she said, sitting upright now, leaning forward, putting her palms on the mattress.

“Sure we do. She loves my dick pics.”

She couldn’t help laughing, crawled to him and hammered the heel of her fist in the middle of his stomach. “Don’t send my mother pictures of your dick.”

“Tell her to stop asking for them,” he laughed.

She sat on her heels and rested her hands on her knees. While he practically trembled with held back laughter, there was something telling in those flashing blue eyes. “Do you? Do you talk to her?”

“Of course. I really do.”

“No, you don’t.”

“I do, Maggie.”

“What do you mean?”

“Relax. She bugs me now, too. Stuff about the wedding. Things I need to remember, things I need to do.”

“For real?”

“What do you think?”

“It does sound like something she would do,” she said seriously, eyes shifting across the room as she considered it.

“She does. I don’t mind. Recently, she’s been sending me articles on cases she thought I might find interesting.”

“Why would she do that?”

“I think she’s fishing for dick pics.”

She laughed again, threw herself on him, wishing she didn’t have the strength to fight the incredible urge to put her lips against his. Instead, she curled up in his lap, and rested her ear against the center of the ‘F’ on his sweatshirt.

Cole put a hand on her shoulder, whispered, “Don’t worry, the plans we make are for your own good.”

She knew he was kidding, but she wondered if he was aware of the pain those words delivered. Sure it was good humor now, all fun and games, but this idea that her mother was a Machiavellian force in her life wasn’t untrue. And while she laughed, cuddled against him, her insides tightened again, and a dread worked sinuously from her past to slither its way through her insides and grip her heart. A mild grip, weak fingers circling, giving her heartbeat something to fight against, letting her know it was still there.

She brought her knees a little higher and wrapped an arm around his waist. It felt good to lay on him, and she silently watched out the window at the mottled green-gray out there, the angry discontent of the outside world.

She was warm. Too warm. A dampness now under her arms, even dotting her upper lip. An uncomfortable wave washed up her back and settled on her like a weight. She groaned and got up, stood at the side of the bed.

“Where you going?”

“Nowhere,” she said, then something came over her and she didn’t resist. Thumbs hooked in her waistband and she slipped the sweatpants down to the floor and stepped out of them, her back to Cole, her long sweatshirt draped to the top of her thighs but showing him all of her legs.

“Oh, come on,” he said behind her.

She bent over, showed him her panties, picked up the sweatpants and threw them on her dresser. “What?”

“Really?”

“Really what?” she said as he gestured with his palms and a smirk, indicating her disrobing.

She smiled, said, “What ...? ... I’m too hot.”

He folded his arms, said, “You *are* too hot.”

Now she folded her arms, too, began to twist back and forth playfully. “How hot am I?”

“Somebody loves compliments.”

“That’s not a compliment.”

“Sorry,” he said, adjusting himself to sit higher as if he had been reprimanded by a teacher. Now he settled his eyes on her, said, “Without a doubt, you are the finest creature that graces this earth.”

“I like that,” she said.

“More?”

She shrugged, showed him noncommittal.

He reached a hand out and she was close enough that he could lay his palm on the side of her thigh and run his thumb up and down her skin just below the edge of her sweatshirt. She liked it. He said, “I don’t know what else to tell you. I don’t know what you want to hear. There’s things I want to say that you don’t want to hear.”

“That’s intriguing,” she said, unfolding her arms and letting them hang at her sides, her hands tucked up in the sleeves.

“You want me to say it?”

“No,” she said coolly. Now she stepped where he couldn’t touch her. The heat was bothering her—and yes, this *could* be considered vampish, but some of this heat was emanating from between her legs—so she removed her panties while he watched. Didn’t let him see her sex, tried to keep eye contact with him. She flung them on the dresser and climbed up on the bed and stood, jouncing up and down.

“Playful Maggie,” he said admiringly.

She got herself bouncing, enough that her toes came off the bed, hunching her head forward so she wouldn’t bump her crown, though she wasn’t tall enough. Cole watched her with delight, and she gripped the bottom hem of her sweatshirt so she wouldn’t reveal herself. She had Cole’s full attention.

“This is my kind of show,” he said while she continued bouncing.

She stopped then, walked herself closer, looked at that smiling handsome face of his, stood on one leg and pressed her other foot between his legs, on the generous soft bulge behind the cotton. He held her ankle.

“What are you doing?” he said.

“Nothing,” she said as she slowly peeled up the hem of her sweatshirt held low. A little out from her body, curling it upward to reveal just a tiny

bit of her. Cole's eyes were intent. He watched what she showed him. She flashed it closed again, smiling. In his hand he held his phone, angled up, daring her.

She was in an adventurous mood, and a smile spread on her face that she couldn't fight. She did it again, showed him, lifting that shirt away, feeling the cool air against her hot damp creases. He snapped a picture, a devilish and satisfied look on his face.

"Co-ole!" she chastised him and dropped to her knees making both of them bounce and heave on the bed. She slapped his stomach with both her hands. He was laughing, working on his screen, drawing his knees up to protect himself.

"What are you going to do?" she asked, though she knew what he would do. Cole worked away, his face lit up from the screen held down low, his scruffy cheeks dimpled by a mischievous smile. When he was done he set the phone face down on his stomach.

"Did you send it?"

"What do you think?"

She went down on her hip and lay at his side, put her head on his chest again. After a quiet moment, she said, "Did he answer yet?"

"KEN, please, just five more minutes ... let me be ... I want to be honest."

Ken paused, unable to hide a certain exasperation in his posture. He'd packed up his coffee cup, tucking the tab in the empty container and gathering his phone as if to leave. He hesitated.

"Please," Max said.

He nodded and flashed five fingers over to Brian who still waited by the entrance to the diner. He settled back across from Max and indicated for him to continue. It was funny, as much as Ken played the poor victim, long-suffering boy from the cold and insupportable Becker household, he still had the callous Becker blood coursing through his very own veins. Max rarely saw it in his Maggie but worried that it was there, too.

"I like who Maggie is. That's not it at all. I wanted this for her, but you know how impressionable she is. You know how she can be manipulated. She wants so much to be part of something, to be loved, to love, all the

things she missed from when she ... well, you know how it was, how she grew up ... sheltered. She wants what she imagines other people have. Here,” he said, adding emphasis by putting his hand over his heart.

Ken was nodding now, still expressionless but at least his appeal was meeting less resistance.

“I love her so much and when she expressed ... a certain inexperience, a ...” he exhaled, looking for words that wouldn’t appear too graphic for his Maggie’s brother. “A curiosity for things she didn’t know ... I supported it. Out of love. Only now ...”

In perfect timing with his pause his phone buzzed with an incoming text. Expected what it may be and turned it to face him, saw it was from Cole.

He continued while huffing and his eyes turned to his screen. “You see ...” he said, flicking his thumb across the text, saw there was an attachment. “I fucked up, Ken. I let others I trusted be intimate and they ...”

The text app filled the screen. A message from Cole. The attachment was an image. He swiped it and held his screen so Ken could witness whatever it was surreptitiously without Max purposely showing him. It filled the screen of his phone. A young girl’s legs were the focus, he knew they were Maggie’s. She stood over the photographer, legs slightly apart, holding the hem of her shirt out, flashing the camera. Maggie’s face wasn’t visible, but her engagement ring was evident where she clutched the hem of the sweatshirt. Between her legs was that sweet slit, sleepy and crisply folded, but bared just the same. He sighed shakily and turned the phone face down on the tile.

“... they changed her, Ken. She’s not the same girl.”

Ken’s face was grim, and it made Max assume he’d caught a glimpse of the photo of his sister’s bared privates. He also heard the plural implication: *They* changed her.

“She *is* impressionable,” he agreed quietly.

“I know. She’s an innocent. Smarter than me by a mile, but too trusting, too credulous.”

Ken nodded, his mouth turned down, and he looked like his stomach had got tight.

Max said, “Cole made her apply to Law School. He just wants her to be with him, he doesn’t care about her future. He cares about his future.”

WITH HER EAR still planted in the 'F' of Cole's sweatshirt, she listened to his heart beating and she watched languidly down his body. Her eyes traced the shape of his cock pressing against the front of his shorts. He wasn't hard, just merely aroused by the things they had done and the prospects. Max hadn't got back to them yet. Made no comment on the dirty, but hopefully fun picture they sent.

Cole said, "Do you think he might be mad?"

"No," she sighed. "He might be busy. His Mom loves to spend time with him when he's there. God, so does his Dad." Vestiges of her mother's controlling words worked over her shoulders.

She extended a finger to the flap of his fly, ran it over the frayed cotton, let it fall off the ridge of the fly and onto the side of his cock. She felt it under the material, felt the torpid resistance, pliant yet resilient; let her finger trace its length, found the ridge of his cock head under the foreskin. His cock lay sideways toward a hip, and she ran her finger forward and backward, witnessing it swell against the fabric.

Now she bounced off the bed, hurdling his body like a gymnast over a balance beam. Landing on the floor, she trotted over to Jessie's things.

Cole said, "What are you doing?"

"I'm looking for something," she said. She had one of Jessie's drawers open and was rifling through, picturing what she was looking for, knowing it had to be here somewhere.

"Found it," she exclaimed when her hands scooped it up. She walked back toward him with two hands rolling it out, showing him with a cheeky

smile what she held.

“A tape measure?” he said.

“We’re going to measure you.”

“Oh, my God, Maggie. Seriously?”

“Yeah, we’re gonna measure ...”

He rolled his eyes, said, “Welcome to high school.”

She flinched, feeling suddenly very stupid. He saw the effect his words had and his face was instantly sorry. The damage was done, her feelings deeply hurt. She dropped her arms to her sides, the length of measuring tape between her hands dangling like a skipping rope.

Cole said, “Shit, Maggie, I didn’t mean it like that.”

“We don’t have to,” she said.

The smile never left his face, and he swung his hips so his feet were on the floor, reached out and took both her wrists and pulled her to the bed. She fell on top of him, her face turned away. He rolled onto his back with her and lay her next to him.

“Aw, did I hurt your feelings? Did I hurt your whittle fee-fees?” he said, his thumb caressing her cheekbone. She saw though that his face was serious.

“Is it juvenile?”

“No. It’s fun. I was just trying to be funny. You can do it.”

“Is it stupid?”

“No, Maggie. It’s fun. I mean it, it really is. I want you to. I was just trying to act like I wasn’t into it. You’re being playful. And I think I’m in love with playful Maggie.”

“Are you sure?” she said, sitting up on one hip.

“I’m totally sure. I was just trying to be funny, but I sounded like a jerk. I demand that you do it.”

“I feel so stupid now,” she said, averting her eyes.

“Don’t you dare,” he said. “I don’t want to have to force you to measure it.” His hands came together at his waist, already unbuttoning his pants. The second time today that he was going to reveal himself to her. On a day where she had sworn that she wouldn’t sleep with him. But this wasn’t sleeping, this was just fun. It was friendly, funny, and like he said: she was playful Maggie. This is how they would have behaved before she’d ever been intimate with him. Similar, but of course a lot dirtier.

“Good,” she said, shaking away the hurt. “I want to measure it.”

Cole zipped his fly down, pushed his pants and shorts to his thighs. She watched that thing he had bouncing on his leg. As he kicked his shorts down. He said, "You're in luck, because my dick is getting so hard from how fucking smart you are."

"How smart I am?" she laughed.

"It's a turn on."

She slumped onto her heels, closed her eyes and cocked her head like she'd fallen asleep. She pretended to snore. "Zzz-zzz," she mocked.

Cole laughed, said, "Oh, sorry. I say smart? I meant because you're so hot."

"Now I'm waking up," she said fluttering her eyes as if she had been asleep. When they opened she saw deep into Cole's blues as he stared at her. "What?" she said.

He nudged his chin, pointing low down his body, between his legs, a charming smile on his face.

"What?" she repeated.

"Well?" He thrust his hips a little and his heavy cock bounced on his leg.

"Oh," she laughed. "I don't think it's appropriate, Cole. I just do the measuring," she said, running the tape measure tight between her two hands and smiling back at him over it. "You're responsible for the hardening."

"Let me put it to you this way, Maggie: That tape measure doesn't touch me until I'm a hundred-and-ten percent. Know what I'm saying? You know how I get cranked to eleven?"

"Do it and I'll watch. You got hard without trouble when I drew you."

"Novelty. Novelty gets me hard."

"My hand on your penis isn't exactly novel."

"Novelty and direct contact by the most beautiful girl at Farmingham," he said, batting his eyelashes.

She regarded him coolly, but stayed motionless.

He sighed, reached to her wrist, took her hand and put it over his bare cock, and she couldn't stifle a giggle though she tried.

"I can feel your pulse in it," she whispered.

"God," he laughed, rolled his eyes, "You sound exactly like the school nurse."

She laughed and lightly spanked his balls, making him jump and draw up his knees.

“Ow, hey,” he laughed.

“Behave,” she scolded him, put her grip around his soft cock and played with it.

The stormy light from the windows was bright enough to fully illuminate her lover’s cock in her hand. She stroked her thumb on it, tugged playfully on his foreskin, then peeled it right back and squeezed tight so his cock head squirted out of its sleeve then darkened and swelled roundly. Cole grew hard in her hand. She was silent the whole time, listening to her heart beating in her ears, slick skin on skin sounds, and the damp crackle of Cole’s foreskin. She’d grown so tense and focused she was grinding her teeth.

She whispered, “Max isn’t small, right?”

“Maggie, I told you—I don’t know.” Then he watched her a moment, thinking. “No. I don’t think he looks small. He has a normal one. Why do you think it’s small?”

“I don’t. Not really. Sometimes I like to tell him he’s small,” she said, letting Cole’s throbbing erection lay on his belly.

“Why?”

“I think he likes it. You should see his face.” She mimicked her Maxy for him, showed him that mean-but-hurt paradox he assumed. Cole started laughing, and she struggled to keep the face going, her mouth kept stretching to smile.

“Wait, wait, stop laughing,” she said, slapping his knee. She shook her head to clear the giggles, re-assumed her impression of Max, then in a low, dumb voice, she said, “Is it small? Maggie ...” but she couldn’t continue. Cole had turned red from laughing, clasp his face in his hands and bellowing into them. She laughed so hard she couldn’t breathe, bent over until her forehead touched the sheets. She went into a coughing fit.

“Don’t laugh,” Cole choked, “that’s mean.”

“You’re laughing.”

“I’m laughing at you. Laughing at your impression.”

“Fine, fine. I love my Max,” she sighed, wiping at her cheeks. Then looking down at his erection, gaging its rigidity with her eyes, she said, “I think you’re ready.”

“I am. Go ahead,” he said, and he went to his back and laced his hands behind his head, his cock so hard it stuck up toward his chest and wagged stiffly with his movements.

Maggie said, "So how do you do this?" winding the tape measure around an index finger and then unwinding it.

Cole said, "Use a tape measure? You've ever used a tape measure?"

"Ha, ha, I mean do you do it from the side? From where?"

Cole said, "I don't know, I had a summer internship at a dick measuring company but they never let me work the ruler ..."

"The top, right?" she said.

Cole ran his fingertips up and down his shaft, keeping it turgid. He said, "I wouldn't mind if you measured it from the mattress up."

"No cheating," she laughed.

"The top," he said.

While she hesitated, stifling a wider smile she watched her friend as he looked at his own penis in his grip. Watched as he probably brought up his dirtiest thoughts so he would maximize his reading. Smiled to herself wondering what those dirty thoughts might be.

"Okay," she said, "let me," and she lay her hands on his belly, slid the heels down to his crotch so his penis was straight up in the air. Cole held himself just below the glans between a thumb and forefinger. She pressed the end of the tape into his pubic hair and then ran the plastic material straight up, taking over for his hand and gripping him, letting the tape scroll over the bulbous end of him. She read it, said, "Um, seven and a bit ..."

Cole said, "And a bit? Seven-and-a-half. Clearly seven-and-a-half."

"Hmm," she grumbled. "Kind of like seven-and-a-quarter, Cole."

"Well, I don't know what to tell you, the loss of that quarter-inch is probably your fault. It's taking too long. Too clinical ..."

"Should I go put on lingerie?"

"Oh, my God, you're joking but I seriously would fucking love that."

"I don't really have any lingerie."

"Totally naked works too," he said, and ran a hand over her bare knee.

"What's normal for length? Six inches?"

Cole shrugged. "I guess."

"I think it's six."

"Google it."

"I don't want that in my search history."

"Please, I'd go to jail for my search history."

She ignored him, smirking, said, "Okay, lay it on your belly."

Cole did, giving himself a couple of strokes again, flexing his stomach muscles and his hips, and she watched the shaft of his cock widen and bulge.

She said, "Can you move it?"

"What? Where?"

"No, you just flexed it."

"Oh." He took his hand away, flexed it again a few times making it jump up and down, and she fought a giggle that bubbled up inside her, fear of being called a high-schooler again.

"Very muscular, Cole," she said.

"He and I go to the same gym."

"Okay," she laughed, then ran the back of her wrist over her cheeks, feeling hot and damp.

"Would you just admit you're horny?"

"No."

"You are."

She smirked. "No, I'm not."

"Look in my eyes and tell me you don't want to fuck me right now."

"Nope."

"Drawing me naked, measuring my dick, showing me your pussy ...? Can we just fuck already? You're driving me crazy."

Now she did giggle. "All right, all right, let's see ..." She slipped the tape measure underneath it, then took both sides of the tape and sawed it back and forth under his shaft until she got it snug. She put the zero in the center of his shaft, held in place with the tip of her thumb and wound the tape around. She said, "Almost seven."

"Almost? Just call it seven."

"God, what does it matter?"

"What does it matter? You're asking me? You're the one that wanted to measure it."

"Well, I just know it's big." Then she said, "So, what's normal for girth?"

"No idea."

"I think you're much bigger than normal."

"Thank you."

"Not that I have a lot of experience or anything. You're bigger than Max, and thicker than Jay. But Jay was pretty thick, and, like, really long,

too.”

“Fuck off with that.”

“What?” she asked, worried, seeing he wasn’t joking.

“Fuck off with that.”

“But yours is perfect. My absolute favorite. And ... *it’s yours.*”

He stayed expressionless.

She said, “I love your balls. The way they hang, and how big they are ...” she held his balls and ran a thumb over the tops of them.

“I don’t play those games, you know? The ones that Max likes. That’s cool ... you know ... for him. I get him, I love him. I don’t get off hearing about you with another guy. I hate it. Max is okay. Obviously. But I don’t want to know one detail about you and anyone else.”

“You don’t think it’s hot?” she asked, thumb still stroking a testicle.

“Not in the slightest.”

“Are you mad at me?”

He sat up partially, gripped the front of her sweatshirt and pulled her to his kiss. She let herself be taken, let him kiss her fully because she felt like she might have hurt *his* whittle fee-fee now and she didn’t want that. She kissed him back, slow at first then a little quicker, a little deeper. When they broke away he said, “You want to turn me on, you tell me how you want only me. I’ll tell you the same.”

She licked her lips and held his gaze until she couldn’t anymore and it drifted down between them. “Lay back,” she whispered. Now she slowly put a knee on the other side of him, straddling his thighs but tugging her sweatshirt down to hide her bare sex from him.

He whispered, “What are you doing?”

“Nothing,” she said.

He rested his hands on her bare thighs, and she let him stroke up and down. She walked herself a little higher, felt the heat from his erection between her legs.

“I feel you, you know,” he said.

“I feel you, too.”

“Let me put it in you.”

“No.”

“Jesus, Maggie,” he groaned. “What the fuck?”

“Can’t we just be friends, Cole,” she chuckled.

“You’re so silly,” he said, smiling warmly at her.

His hips began to sway a little, and she could feel the slightest tickle as the underside of his shaft stroked along her sex. She was undeniably aroused, the touch of him against her slippery like oil. She planted her hands on either side of his waist and looked in his eyes, hers narrow, mimicking his. Both of them stifling wider smiles, waiting for the other to break first. But they were both steely and disciplined, and neither would give in. She lowered her hips and let her sex rest on his hardness. His lips twitched.

His thumbs began to make circles on her thigh. She let her sex slip farther up his shaft. When he groaned finally, she did as well. Giving in felt glorious.

Now he let go, chuckling briskly, his hands working up and down her thighs a little more enthusiastically.

With her eyes still on his she reached between them and took the hem of her sweatshirt and lifted it a little higher. Cole's eyes dipped down, and she followed them. Saw his thick erection between her thighs, the shining rosy end of him peeking out of its wrinkled sleeve. Such a dirty but welcome sight and it got her moaning again.

"Tell me about it," he whispered before groaning as well.

She worked her hips up and down, letting the slit of her opening run along the cable on the underside of his cock. Both of them watched between their legs. Cole lifted her sweatshirt higher, helping her, running his thumbs underneath and lifting it as high as her belly button.

She moaned and groaned, chuckling and sighing. Her eyes down again, feeling herself running more and more slick, her sweat building inside, Cole's thumbs ran circles on her tummy and he got her vision narrow again. She bit and sucked her lips, fought the urge to lean forward and take his mouth with hers, let him grip that thing and put it up inside her, instead continued her teasing though she suffered as badly as he did. She ran her hips high, the opening of her pussy slipping right up over his glans, feeling its slick rounded shape slightly part her folds, and she polished it with her wetness using just the swiveling of her hips.

"Oh, fuck," Cole sighed and his eyelids fluttered.

She squeezed her muscles, her opening snagging on his foreskin and she reeled her hips back and exposed his glans fully, the pure sexual sight of his sensitive bulb completely exposed making her eyes flutter now too.

Cole whispered, "You've got a good grip. You've got a strong pussy."

She laughed, let her head fall forward, hunched her back, let her slick stripe slip along his underside, and squashed it down on his scrotum.

He said, "I have so much fun with you."

She said, "Me, too. With you."

"Let me put it in you. Just one time. In and out."

"No," she groaned, feeling herself leaking over his balls, feeling their soft shapes slipping over her slickness. "Send Max a picture with my, you know, girl parts on it."

"No, don't do that ..."

"Why not?"

"Don't be mean to Max."

"It's not mean. He likes it. You know he likes it."

"I don't want to taunt him, Maggie. I just want to fuck you. So bad."

"It's not taunting. It'll turn him on."

"Turn him on?"

"Do it," she said, feeling her breaths coming short and hitching in her chest. She tugged the front of her sweatshirt up and slipped her wet little sex up his shaft again and it made Cole gasp.

Cole's eyes watched between them, focused on his cock and her pussy slipping on it while his hand felt around seeking his phone again. He found it, brought it to his chest, still watching the live contact.

"Okay?" she whispered.

He nodded, got the camera live.

"I'm filming," he whispered.

She sucked her lips in her mouth while he pointed the camera between their legs and she felt his cock touch her labia, squeezed her muscles on it, slipped up high near his glans and pulled back his foreskin and watched again as that big shining desperate cock head swelled free. The sight of it pounded her heart and she ached to have it inside her.

When his phone dinged as he stopped recording, she gasped, "Oh, fuck," and fell forward inhaling deeply, lust pounding her pulse up her neck.

"Look at your face," Cole sighed as he opened his text messenger.

"What about it?" she said.

"Your cheeks are *glowing*," he said.

She felt the heat on them. "Yeah," she agreed.

Cole's thumbs tapped the screen while he worked. "You sure about this?"

"Yeah," she gasped and lay her hands on his chest.

"You want him to give you permission?"

She shrugged and looked away.

"With this?" he asked, turning his phone to her. She saw the brief repeating video image: A close up of her spread legs, Cole's cock between them, running along her sex, she reels her hips back and it pulls his foreskin and his cock head practically pops out.

"Send it," she whispered.

"You already have permission. You told him. We're open."

"Just send the picture, will you?"

He turned the screen to himself and his thumbs began typing away. He said, "Should I ask him how his folks are?"

"Don't."

He stopped a moment and met her gaze, let the phone down. "It's weird, huh?"

"Weird and it might make him defensive. I want him happy."

He resumed typing and when he was done, he turned the phone so she could see it. There was that lewd video, no identifying marks, no faces. Underneath it, he had typed:

Cole: Thumbs up, buddy, if you want more

She extended an index finger and pressed the circular green send button.

BOTH KEN and Max sat in silence in the space underneath the escalator, their heads turned out to the concourse, watching people pass, flickering the visage of Brian as he patiently waited on the other side.

Ken said, "What makes you sure there's a video?"

"I'm ninety-nine percent sure there's a video. Unless someone's lying to me. To us."

"What do you think would happen if you showed Maggie the video?"

Max said, “I came here thinking that if I could get it, if she saw herself the way you saw her ... That if she saw herself on video, she would hate it. Hate the things she does. And that would help her to stop.”

“That’s a long way to come for a video. Did you think of just emailing me?”

“Not the kind of thing you do over email, Ken.”

“I suppose not.”

Max said, “I’ll let you go. I guess I wasted my time.”

“I’m sorry I can’t help you, Max.”

Max stood up and held a hand to help Ken. When Ken was standing he said, “You could call her. You could let her know you saw us.”

“I can’t do that, Max.”

“Maybe we could save her,” he said hopefully.

“I hear what you’re saying, Max. I just don’t like it. I don’t like subterfuge. I would never want to trick my sister.”

“It’s the truth. You did see us.”

“I just don’t want to be a part of something like this.”

“Call her and tell her you saw it. But don’t tell her I came here.”

“You see, this is what I’m saying,” he said and winced, turning away from Max and nodding to Brian.

Max said, “I understand, Ken. I sound crazy. Maybe I am crazy. It might seem like all I care about is myself, sometimes I think what I do—it’s only for me and I hate that. I hate it because I love your sister. I love her and I’m going to marry her.”

“Take care, Max,” Ken said and extended a hand to shake.

Max looked in his eyes, both of them wary, then averting their gazes. He shook Ken’s hand. “Good to see you, Ken.”

“I have to get going now. I came here for a lot of things and I don’t want to miss them. Hug my sister for me,” he said, then stopped to add: “unless that gives away you were here.”

As he walked away Max patted him on the back and put his hands in his pockets. Ken wove through the passing crowds to rejoin Brian. They both tossed their coffee cups in a trashcan and then got very close and spoke to each other quietly. Brian put his hand on Ken’s waist while they whispered in each other’s ears. Then the two of them gave Max a wave and a nod and headed to the escalator, on their way to lunch and then to watch the CRISPR demo.

"I THINK he's mad at us."

"No. He can't be," she said.

"He hasn't returned a single text, Maggie."

"They're probably out doing something together. I think his sister is home, I bet they went out somewhere for brunch and they're not even home yet."

"He has his phone with him."

She groaned and lay her cheek on his chest. She still straddled him, his cock was still throbbing at her entrance.

Cole said, "I can't believe I'm the one trying to wreck this. I just want to fuck so bad right now, but I don't want to hurt Max's feelings."

"He likes it, I swear."

He ran his hands over her back. "If you say so. You already told him. We've fucked behind his back be—"

"Not *behind* his back, Cole."

"Kind of behind his back."

"That's not true. We're *not* having an affair ..."

He was silent for a while and then his hands went in circles again, rubbing her warm dry sweatshirt over the muscles of her back and her eyes began to narrow with the delightful comfort that brought. However, between her legs she was very aware of his arousal, unwavering, throbbing. She wanted Max to return a text so badly.

He whispered, "You know you and I are a couple."

"Couple of what?"

“Come on.”

“What?” she giggled.

“You’re meant to be with me.”

“Cole ...”

“I’m not trying to steal you from Max. You’ll come to me on your own.”

“Come on, Cole,” she said, patting his chest and sitting upright so she could look at him. She found his face serious. He wasn’t joking around, wasn’t teasing her or being playful.

“You know it’s true, Maggie. I don’t want to hurt Max, but you and I are perfect together.”

The underside of his cock slipped across her again, making her eyes flutter. Next to them, face up on the bed, Cole’s phone sat black and faceless, no word from the boy she agreed to marry. Her hips worked her pussy up his hardness.

“Maybe ... maybe we could ...” Her voice trailed to a dry, empty croak. Her eyes had stayed on his, but they lowered now to his masculine pouting mouth, those beautiful berry lips. She drew closer. What was the rest of her sentence? Maybe we could what ...? ... Fuck just a little? Maybe we could only do anal again? There wasn’t anything to say. Her lovely Max was away with his mom and dad and his bad fiancée had pretty much entered into a romantic relationship with his best friend. And one rule she gave herself: keep your hands off him while Max is at home.

She put her lips so close to his; she could feel their heat, feel the soft breath from him. “Maybe ... we could show Max. Show him some more. Maybe we’ll do it for him.”

Cole took her mouth tenderly then, and she floated off, an ecstatic arrhythmia taking control of her heart. She sucked on his lower lip while he stroked her upper with the tip of his tongue.

“I’ll do anything to be with you,” he whispered. “Whatever it is we’ll do it, Maggie ...”

She sensed it coming, and she put up a makeshift wall: “Don’t say it, Cole ...”

“Maggie, I love you.”

“Oh, no, Cole, don’t ...”

“I love you so much ...”

The force of that wave washed her crummy construction away, threw her clumsy rock wall down and cast the stones far up her coast. He was taking her now, sitting up, rolling over on top of her and she let him. Went to her back and lay her head on the mattress, exposed her neck, enfolded her lover in an embrace. Her knees drew up.

Cole hooked a forearm under one and it exposed her sex completely. She felt his arousal between her legs, felt that fat glans of his resting in her folds, slipping up and down the curve of her mound as he took her mouth with kisses. She wanted him inside her so bad, wanted to be consumed by him, wanted to lose herself in passion with a boy who was her best friend. One as close to her as her very own Max, one who rocked her world and did mind-bending things to her sexually.

She whimpered suddenly seeing her Max so diminished. She saw him so small now, so small in comparison to the man she was with, the man who was his best friend. All three of them sharing a close and wonderful friendship, her heart as open to Cole as the boy who put a ring on her finger and she'd promised herself to, who had given her licentious license. But Cole was no more merely a friend and these days, though she loved him depthlessly, Max's disparity to Cole in the sack was pronounced. Maybe she'd not thought of it, pushed it away for a long time, but it was true and she couldn't turn her cheek from it.

She humped her clit against the weight of Cole's cock and ran her nails up and down his back. He groaned into her kiss and his hips wound back, the tip of his cock slipping along her wet folds and finding her entrance. She threw a leg around his waist, the other held back as Cole pressed her knee up to her collar. Then he entered her and there was something about his cock inside her body that made her feel complete.

She'd been so wet with need his girth made no pain, his whole length sliding deep inside her body, seven thick inches buried inside her, making her heart pound, making it beat faster and faster.

"Ah, God, Cole ... just hold it there," she breathed and shut her eyes, ran her fingernails through his thick blonde hair, every interior muscle massaging her lover's organ, feeling every bit of it, sensing every vein, every cable; could feel the shape of its head distinctly moving inside her like a knot, his foreskin peeled right back by her tightness. "Hold it," she urged again, feeling a tension in him, feeling his desire to fuck her building, knowing he wanted to thrust it in and out of her. Cole had stamina and

discipline, and he let her sculpt his cock with her insides, let her membranes squish and squeeze on him, the slightest slip of their sexes now zipping white lines behind her eyes. “Ah, fuck, oh,” she finally gasped when her stomach muscles cramped with the effort. “Oh, Cole, oh, fuck me.”

Then he withdrew and plunged his full size again, going deep and holding, and as she tried to squeeze him again, he withdrew and plunged once more. It got her gasping, soft, breathy sounds as he did it over and over. Withdrawing till the tip of him came right out and then back in, spreading her wide and deep. He gripped her behind the knee with one strong hand and pushed so that the knee touched her ear. She cried out with pleasure. She exposed herself to his impaling. In and out, fully each time, tip to balls, until he had her yelling. Calling his name and babbling in his year, her nails scratching at his neck to pull him for another kiss.

He fed her his tongue, and she took it, opening her mouth and sucking him inside as willingly as she was doing between her legs. “Aw, that’s it,” she gasped around his tongue, the plunging between her legs driving her wild.

Then he took his hand and slid it inside her thigh, gripped the opposite knee now as well. Guiding it up so that it was over her ear, too. Above her, she only saw his face, his chest, her calves. Cole looked in her eyes as he slowed his pace, became gentle and easy and it had her moaning. She stroked the backs of her thighs with her hands, then his hips, her nails running along his skin.

“Yeah, more,” she whispered. She wasn’t sure what more she wanted—just more of everything. Regretted now studying today, wishing that if she were going to give in she had given in earlier, and they could’ve made love all day long, right through the phonecall with her mother.

She worked her hands between her knees, brought them up so she could cup her lover’s face. She stroked his cheeks with her thumbs, her mouth hanging open, and Cole went in and out of her.

She whispered, “I want to be on top of you.”

He let one knee down so he could caress her face. He stroked her cheek with a thumb as she did to him, hips stirring gently into her. He didn’t say anything just licked his lips, lusty eyes drilling into hers. Then he was withdrawing, and when his penis was out of her she complained about its absence, whimpering and frowning. But he drew up rapidly, holding her by her hands until they were face-to-face on their knees. He cupped her neck

and kissed her deeply. She let her hands stroke his body, her nails dancing across him, drifting low to his hips then between his legs. One hand stroked him and the other ran her nails over his hanging balls. It got Cole groaning.

He was a masterful lover, and she loved it when he took her. But that was the greatest thing between them. The lovemaking was always different. Capable of great and wonderful dichotomy. She could bend to him, let him tie her hands up and fuck her lifeless body. Make her squirt all over a window at an expensive hotel. They could be playful, engage in silly games of nudity and teasing. They ran the gamut. And just as he could dominate her she could dominate him, too. He was no weakling, and he wanted to explore a dominant woman like her. It wasn't in her, at least not at the surface. But something in his eyes drew it from deep inside her. A caged little tiger, at once timid and yet curious, peeking out past the door left open.

He sat back down, letting his butt drop between his heels then kicking his feet out and she fell toward him, her hands on his chest and his lips on hers still. Now she was over top of him, climbing up his waist, her mouth still working over his. She reached behind, got a handful of testicles, fondled them and gripped them hard until he grunted. Her hand eased up the shaft, gripped him lightly now and angled him toward her interior. She stroked herself with him, gripping in the middle and moving it up and down so that his covered tip slipped back and forth between her slippery labia.

"Oh, fuck," he groaned and laughed around their kiss.

She groaned too, teasing him had her as mad as she intended to drive him. Now she was smiling and looking in his eyes. She pierced herself with the round helmet, his stiffness intense enough that she could let him go and hold his shoulders and look in his eyes as she sat herself back on his hips, feeling every bit of him grinding up inside her body again. She exhaled wonderful joy, and let him see the beatific expression on her face, wanting to communicate to him the enormous love between them.

Cole was devastatingly handsome. It was undeniable, everyone knew when they saw him. His rugged jaw, stubble, deep and soulful yet piercing blue eyes. The tan of his tight skin, the golden blond of his long hair—his beauty was undeniable. Almost unachievable, out of reach, meant only for the most lucky. Only she didn't feel lucky riding him. She felt like she was one with him. Had been his friend for so long. A friendship that was deep and loving and trusting and now they shared each other physically. His head

lay back in her pillow where she slept every night. His thick blond hair spread out around him, those beautiful eyes narrow and twinkling in the stormy light.

Her mouth fell open, her breaths were short and quick. His big penis was inside her, right up in her belly, and she was in control of it. She rocked her hips on him, felt that knot of a glans working up and down inside her. And then he held his hands out for her to take them and her heart swelled in her chest. She laced her fingers between his, gripped him tight and he held her loosely, let her dig her nails into the back of his hands. She sunk deeper then, on her knees, rising up and down on him, feeling him slipping in and out, she got herself gasping. Her lover lay under her, his arousal like steel, his eyes burning into hers.

“Oh,” she gasped, suddenly feeling a slippery quicksilver snake wriggle up from the apex, somewhere low, somewhere gynecological; winding a corkscrew up around her heart, then over the back of her scalp. She looked down and saw her nipples turn to hard brown buds. Cole saw it too, and he whispered her name as she felt his hips began to rock into hers, giving her a rhythm to syncopate against.

She fell forward over top of him, her hair scratching over his shoulders, around his cheeks, and she took his lips.

She had it.

She had complete control of it.

Her breath scored in and out of her nose and she squished him inside her, finding the perfect path of her hips, grinding her clitoris in his pubic hair, that helmet of his pushing against the front wall of her membranes, stiff and hard, a point of pressure for her to work against. He held himself stiffly for her, looked in her eyes and she met his gaze through narrow slits until her breath came in gulping snorts.

He whispered, “That’s it, Maggie, let me watch you come.”

His words were all she needed to get a leg up over that big old wall and throw herself to the bottomless other side, falling and falling, the wind whipping her hair, a pleasure so enormous and boundless all around her. She humped faster and faster, her eyes fluttering, gasping and grunting until she fell on him, her face buried in that thick hair, her nose on his earlobe.

SHE SAW COLE AS A FUZZY, burnt umber silhouette against a pale fog. Her eyes blurred and phosphorescent blobs bloomed and blossomed, wandering in her vision and flaring with the beat of her heart. Somehow Cole was above her and she didn't remember getting herself onto her back. His hand caressed her neck and slowly his handsome face came into focus.

"I do love you, Maggie. I loved you as a friend for a long time but now I really know you ..."

Her mouth hung open and the rasping noise she heard was her own breath, her chest heaving up and down. She nodded her head, acknowledging those wonderful words. Then slippery electric excitement zipped up from her heart again, the head of his cock slipping back and forth over her opening. She nodded for more, and then he was entering her, bringing her right to the edge of that wall again. She gasped and gulped his name, dug her nails into his shoulders as she felt him slide deep inside her once more.

"Oh, Cole," she whispered.

Her nails dragged around behind his neck, she clutched herself to him as he impaled her deeply, withdrew and did it again. He fucked her like that, very slow, very deep, and very loving. Working in and out with inexorable certainty. Each thrust, each withdrawal racing her heart.

She heard the wetness between them, heard her sex opening like a slick flower, accepting him fully. Soon her hips were working, her tummy rolling, her pelvis tilting forward and up, being pressed back, tilting forward and up, eager to be penetrated again. His thumb still caressed her jawline, and now she ran her nails down his arms, pinching the backs of his hands, clutching them, pulling them to the side. He did, intertwined their fingers, spread her arms wide.

She opened her mouth and tilted her chin to the ceiling and he took her with a passionate kiss. It began all over again, pounding renewed in her heart, a passion swelling and roaring inside her; she gripped his hands hard, her fingers scissoring tightly over his and he crushed her grip in return.

They both inhaled and exhaled in unison, their breaths snorting over one another, his thrusting becoming short and contracted. Just their hips dancing against one another without music, needing only the syncopation of their heartbeats. She began to muffle blurted air around him, high gasps and groans in her throat that she couldn't stop. He was going to make her come again, and it was going to be even better than the first time.

She hitched her legs around him, dug her heels into his rump and forced him deeper. When she came, she wanted him all the way inside her.

Over his shoulder she saw a pale figure passing from right to left. She gasped into Cole's kiss. That squirrely, but much desired, orgasm slipping out of her grip. It was a girl, she was blonde, and she held her hand up between her face and Maggie's; it was Jessie.

The badness spun up inside her, a shameful tornado, but it spiraled out of kilter, its energy dissipating and disappearing leaving only specks of dust in its wake. She *wanted* to be seen.

She gasped a little louder, accepted Cole fully again, ran her nails up his back sharply making him growl. It was a sexy masculine animal sound, and it made Jessie giggle.

Jessie said, "Don't mind me, guys. Getting some things and getting right out. And once more for the hard of hearing: put the damn handkerchief on the doorknob," and then she giggled again.

Maggie grunted and gasped, made deep sexual sounds. It was a display though it didn't take much acting. Cole flinched at the sound of Jessie's voice, but he didn't stop, feeling Maggie's willingness compelling him, her hungry opening swallowing him and sucking him deep. It made him grunt, too.

Jessie gathered her things while Maggie bucked hard against Cole. Threw some items of clothing into a bag, zipped it closed and heaved it over her shoulder, throwing a hand up again between them as she walked back to the door. Before she disappeared, before she was blotted out by Cole's handsome visage, Maggie clearly saw Jessie's wet, blinking, brilliant blue eyes meet hers in round shock the instant before she passed.

Being seen like that—her base and lubricious nature revealed, her deep sexual value exposed to someone who had been her roommate and considered her a good girl from day one—poured jet fuel into her motor. She practically purred, arched her back, and Cole met it with aggression, driving her into the bed, her head being forced back into the headboard, banging it into the wall.

Somewhere she heard Jessie gasp, "Holy shit, oh, my God." She heard the door close.

Something like a laugh whorled up inside her, working in circles, making her open her mouth as if she were regaling though no sound came out. A victorious feeling, a recognition, a feeling of a circle made complete.

A loop drawn in a crescent, searching and magically finding its origin again. Perfection in totality. Her spirit, her intelligence, her spark, sexuality, all plugged in, batteries charged, the motor of her soul vibrating and humming.

She found it again, that swirling chrome globe of ecstasy, pinpointed it in her frontal lobe, squeezed with a focus, riling it up again, bringing its swell to raise her high. “I’m coming, I’m coming, I’m coming,” she gasped and moaned into Cole’s ear as she ran her nails up his back. Her heels kicked into him, spurring him, digging into his rump, her words making Cole groan now, too, his thrusting ceasing, digging deep instead and holding it inside her.

She heard the door again, saw Jessie return, her face reddened, cheeks blushing, eyes wet. She was coming toward her, now the focus was lost, that slippery orgasmic globe swirling into the ether and she moaned with displeasure.

Jessie kneeled at the side of the bed, sniffing wetly, a trembling cry in her voice: “Sorry, I have to ... is this okay? Are you okay?”

Maggie gasped, “What?”

Jessie’s eyes were pink and watery, on the verge of crying. “Maggie, do you want to be here?”

Cole said, “Jessie, Jesus, it’s me ...”

But she disregarded Cole, said, “I don’t care. I have to ask. Maggie ...?”

“Yeah,” she gasped and groaned, writhing in the sheets, so excited to be seen this way.

“Are you ...?” Jessie cried. “Do you want to be here? Are you here of your own will?” Her voice trembled and broke, fractured by fear.

Maggie gasped again, a breathy slice of air and she said, “I one ... ah, one-hundred percent want to be he-here ...”

Cole said again, “Jessie, it’s me ...”

“I know it’s you,” she spat. She looked at Cole now, and Maggie didn’t like the eyes not being on her.

“I’ll explain ... oh ... mm-later ...”

Cole said, “It’s cool, Jessie.”

Maggie gasped, “It’s okay ... I want to be here. I really want to be here.” She bucked her hips for emphasis. Cole had stopped, his face indignant, almost hurt.

Jessie wiped at her cheeks, voice still shaky she said, “You want to be here?”

“Yeah,” she gasped again, arching her back and writhing once more.

“Maggie ...”

Then Maggie ruined it, dashed the independence of the moment by saying: “Max knows. It’s okay ... Max knows ...”

Jessie, unable to deal with it, gasped, “Whatever, fine, I don’t care, I just want you to be okay ...”

“Mm, I’m okay, better than ... okay ...”

Cole slipped himself back and forth a little and it made her laugh, the laugh falling away to a high pitched giggle she didn’t even recognize. Now she was one of those girls and her power was incredible.

Jessie backed away, and Maggie gasped, “Wait, don’t go ...”

It slowed Cole’s stroke, made him hesitate, wondering about Maggie’s intention.

“Take ... Take a picture for me,” she asked. Thinking of Max.

“What? No ...”

“Yes, please, Jessie,” and then irrationally: “It’s for a project.”

“Maggie...”

And then a further plea: “Please, Jessie?”

“Oh, no, Maggie ...”

She was urgent, whispering now, “Please, Jessie, the phone,” waving a pointed foot, knowing her phone was somewhere in the surrounding bedding.

“No, Maggie, don’t ...”

“Please, Jessie ...”

Then Jessie was gone and instantly regret fell over her like a heavy sheet. Like in Freshman year, the first time she drank to excess, woke up in the morning wondering all the things she said, remembering only snippets. Wondering how *bad* she had got. An overwhelming regret. And this was like that, the knowledge that while her words made sense in the throes of ecstasy with her beautiful lover, in the cold glow of tomorrow she would not see it the same way.

She moaned, feeling reproach in self-awareness. The first time since she’d begun this endeavor that she looked admonishingly on herself. Cole resumed stroking and while she was flashed with instant pleasure, she knew it would be a long climb up that hill to ecstasy.

At the sound of a digital shutter her eyes opened, saw Jessie standing by the side of her bed, lowering the phone, watching her roommate—who was engaged—fucking her gorgeous Best Man on her dorm room bed. The baseness whirled again, pushing away the shame, or at least facing it down. She nodded for Jessie who didn't nod back, lowered the camera to her side, her face drawn and unhappy. She dropped the phone onto her bed and walked away.

The door closed, and they were alone again. Cole said, "That was fucking crazy, Maggie."

"Was it?" she whined with worry.

"It's okay. I think it's okay. I love you, I love Max. I don't care what it means."

It was the perfect thing to be said. It supercharged her heart, brought her smile wide, and she gasped, "I don't care what it means either."

She raked her nails over his skin, making him hiss, driving his hips forward, pushing that big thing up into her body again, injecting her with hot excitement. She dug her heels, spurred her lover until the thrusting returned. They bucked against each other, they laughed, they kissed, they rolled all over her bed. Sometimes she was on top, sometimes he was. She came. She came again. She'd never felt more free.

Claim

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 21ST

"ARE YOU GOING TO COME?" she whispered in Cole's ear as he drove himself into her hard.

"Yeah, mm," he grunted. "I'm close."

"Ah," she gasped, eager to feel his eruption. She moiled her hips against his thrusts for a while then whispered, "Come on my face."

He slowed. "What?"

"I want you to come on my face."

"You want that?"

"Claim me ... make me yours."

His thrusts slowed, and he held his head back to look in her eyes. "You sure?"

"You come in other girls' faces?"

He held her gaze but said nothing.

"Make me yours, Cole."

His thrust continued, hesitatingly, and he bit his sexy lower lip.

She said, "You don't want to?"

"I want to so bad, Maggie. You've got my heart so worked up," he whispered, and he took her hand in his and lay it over his chest.

She smiled and felt his hot skin, could feel the pounding of his strong heart under her palm. "Okay?" she asked.

"Yeah," he gasped and nodded.

"I really want it, Cole."

His lips trembled, and he fucked her harder while he looked in her eyes with his hand on hers as it lay over his heart. He built it up, got himself

right on the edge and she never took her eyes from his. Their breaths came faster and faster, his thrusting quicker and more urgent. She felt him leaking inside her.

“Okay, Cole, okay ...?”

“Yeah,” he grunted, and he withdrew, jumped up to his knees and she scooted to the pillows and sat with her legs apart.

He got himself close to her, his cock swinging and bobbing before he gripped it and began to jerk himself furiously.

“I want it,” she whispered, and she ran her hands up his thighs and held his balls.

There was a tremble in the muscles of his legs, a flutter in his belly as he stroked himself. Knowing he was close excited him, anticipating the enormity of this moment was driving him. This was going to end with an incredible bonding. He drew it out, and she waited, enjoying the anxious breadth of the moment.

She whispered, “Do it, do it, claim me, Cole.”

His stroke came faster, her eyes narrowed but wanting to see, looking and seeing the veins bulging in his hand, his foreskin stretching and puckering, the head of his cock swollen to bursting proportion, could see slippery excitement seeping from his hole.

“That's it, that's it,” she gasped, her breaths coming as heavily and urgently as Cole's.

He grunted, “Close, mm, close your eyes.”

“I want to watch.”

“Seriously, Maggie, it, ah, it stings if it gets-s in your eyes.”

“How do you know?”

“Just open your mm-mouth ...”

She did, let her mouth fall open, pressed her tongue down and let the tip slip over her lower lip.

“Oh, fuck, Maggie ... ah, Maggie ...” Cole blurted, and she closed her eyes now, felt Cole's hand on her neck, turned her face up to his, gave her the most placid and beatific expression she could. Let her mouth fall open and extended her tongue farther.

Cole roared, the hot animalistic sounds ripping from him charging up her insides, swelling her heart and supercharging her sex. His stroking stopped suddenly and Cole came.

She bubbled wetly between her legs at his masculine expulsion. She felt it then, hot flashes on her face. Up over her forehead, across her cheek, into her eyes, blocking a nostril, splashing in her mouth. She breathed and stretched her tongue farther, curled it till it touched the point of her chin, desperate to feel his seed on her tongue. He landed it there, a hot mess that trickled down into her throat and her tongue darted back to curl it and taste it.

It kept coming; across her nose, pooling in the cup of her left eyeball ... She felt it dribbling down her neck, from her face and onto her collar. The whole while Cole's hand pumped and squeezed, his grunts and roars and groans over top of the slick sound of his hand on his cock.

She wished to encourage him, wanted to say how she loved it but her mouth was held open for him, wanting him to enjoy this moment; and he did. When the spurting stopped, and all that was left was the roar of his breathing, he slipped the head of his penis into her mouth and she took it, swallowed it, let it go right back to her throat then drew her lips to a point, swallowed all that still dribbled from him.

"Oh, my God, holy shit, Maggie," Cole gulped as he took his penis from her mouth and dropped to sit on his heels, both his hands on her neck.

He held her, pulled her close to him, their chests slipping across one another with the wetness of his discharge. She felt so loved in his arms, cradled and safe. She dug the pad of a thumb through her eye and cleared it, tried blinking and felt the sting of his semen. She murmured complaint, and he hugged her tighter.

"Ow," she said, and put the back of her wrist into her eye socket.

Cole let her go, and she bent forward, letting his semen drip to the bedding. But he was on her then, and she felt the warmth of the sweatshirt he wore pressed to her eye and cleaning her. He did it lovingly, with care, cleaning his discharge from her, soft purring groan in his chest as he did.

She stopped him before he could finish, pushed his hand away. She blinked, saw a fractal image of his handsome face watching her with concern. She smiled, said, "That was really hot."

"You're mine now," he said in a low quiet voice.

She nodded but said nothing in return. And then he held her again, pulled her to him and ran his hands in circles around her back and her waist.

She whispered, "Can you take a picture?"

He stiffened. "Are you sure?"

“I think so. I don’t want to leave him out. I don’t want him to be separate from us.”

“Yeah, but ...”

He held her away from him but she could barely see with her eyes still squinted and stinging.

“Take a picture,” she said again.

His body heat left her as he got off the bed and made his way to Jessie’s, retrieving the phone where she dropped it.

“Holy shit, Maggie,” he said.

“What?”

“You’re not going to believe it ...”

“What is it?” she asked, a growing anxiety coming up her back.

“Look,” he said.

“I can’t,” she said, blinking her eyes again.

“Look,” he repeated.

Slowly her eyes opened, lashes fluttering uncontrollably. Cole stood at the side of the bed and he held the phone for her to look.

She murmured, “What ...? I can’t ...”

He moved the phone closer.

There under the last text he had sent—the image of his bulbous cock head underneath her shaved pussy—Cole had texted: *Thumbs up, buddy, if you want more*. And below that, sent from her sweet Max, the emoji of a large thumbs-up.

“He got back to us,” she softly sang. “Oh, my Maxy.”

“He’s not mad at us,” Cole said, turning the phone so he could look again.

“I told you,” she said.

“You feel better now?”

“I do. I feel a lot better.”

“You really want ...? Want me to take this picture?”

“Do I look bad?”

“You look beautiful.”

“Take it, please,” she said. Then added, “Not my whole face, just my mouth and nose, okay?”

“Hold still,” he told her and she closed her eyes and tilted her chin toward him.

He asked, “Max never, you know ...?”

“Came in my face?”

“Did he?”

“You’re the first.”

The sound of the shutter came from the camera and he sat then on the bed. “Did you like it?”

“I liked it ‘cause it was you,” she said, then his warm sweatshirt was back, wiping at her face and she leaned herself against him as he cleaned her.

When he was done, when her face had been dried and his sweatshirt tossed to the floor, he looked in her eyes and smiled. She cupped a hand to his cheek.

He wagged the phone now. “Are you sure I should send this?”

“Yeah. It’s like he’s here with us. It bothers you?”

He nodded. “You’re here with me. Max doesn’t need to be here. You wanted to be open remember?”

“Please send it.”

“Do you want to see it first?”

She shook her head no. “Is it bad?”

“I wouldn’t want it.”

“Max does. My Max does.”

Cole stared at the screen for a while but did nothing.

She said, “Let’s see the one Jessie took. Maybe we send that one first.”

THE ROOM he’d booked for two nights had a king-size bed, and a small pie-shaped balcony with a view inland, toward the city. He entered and walked right past the high, crisply made bed, threw his bag on the blue tweed couch and followed behind, bouncing on it till he settled with his feet up and crossed over. What the fuck was he thinking?

He hadn’t anticipated such resistance from Ken. He’d always seemed so meek and understanding. Way he pictured this going, he had this room for two-nights and had anticipated meeting up with Ken tonight, maybe tomorrow, go out for dinner, go meet some of his friends. If he’d asked, Ken would have obliged, but after that impasse this afternoon he just wanted to be home in Vermont.

His phone buzzed, and he jumped. It was in his front pocket, close to his scrotum. Fished it out with one hand, his mind racing, wanting to see what they had sent him now, his brain saying maybe it didn't really want to see. The last image had been a doozy. Cole and Maggie's bare sex equipment so close. He knew they would fuck, didn't know why she was being so coy. Of course, as much as it hurt his heart, it did make him feel welcome. He sent a thumbs-up. So, feeling a little lighter, he checked his screen and saw this message wasn't from Cole but from his beloved Maggie this time. He smiled.

Maggie: tell me you're okay

He texted:

Max: I'm ok. miss you big time

He pried the heels of his shoes off with his toes and let them fall to the carpet next to the couch.

Maggie: miss you so much. can't wait until ur home with me

Someone was feeling guilty, which was sweet. He'd only been gone for half a day, they normally would be apart this long any day of the week. Still, the distance between them was palpable.

Max: tell me u love me

Maggie: I love you forever

Max: love you too

Maggie: u okay with pics?

He rolled his head from side to side and flexed and stretched his neck.

Max: yeah

There was a long delay, and he watched the screen the whole time. It rose and fell on his chest while he breathed deeply.

Maggie: want another one?

Oh, man, she had him. He mouthed the word *No*, to his phone, but every molecule in his body right now absolutely fucking needed to see this picture. He didn't even say yes, and the picture was sent. It flashed a quick timing wheel and then there it was. The two of them together in her bed. His fiancée and his best friend. Cole was between her legs and they were fucking. Skin a little shiny, laying on her bed, her head in her pillows, right where he had left her this morning. His cock was still sore from all the fucking they did last night but his newly realized sex-demon still needed more plowing. God, she was so sexy, though. He ran a fingertip down her digital calf.

He simply texted:

Max: hot

Maggie: still ok?

Max: love you more than ever

He lay there for another long while and no more texts came. He typed one:

Max: Did you study?

There was a delay while he waited, but then, finally, she texted:

Maggie: I did. and I drew Cole :)

He laughed. Hoped they had fun today. Hoped they were silly and light, and that they thought of him.

Max: Tied him up with your pink tights?

Maggie: Ha ha, he wasn't trying to get away

Max sat up and put his feet on the floor. Zipped his bag down and fished out a T-shirt and sweatpants he'd packed. While he changed, he lay the phone face up on the seat cushion of the couch. Before he slipped his shirt on, he touched the screen to scroll back to the new photo. Put his shirt on, bent over and examined it again. It was a hot photo. He wasn't lying. Their faces weren't visible, but he knew it was Maggie. It was her feet, her ankles, her hand on Cole's arm. It was Cole who was between her legs, he could see the thick, long blonde hair. Something bothered him, and he finally realized what it was. He scrolled back down, typed:

Max: Hey, who took that picture?

He sat with his phone for five minutes but she didn't get back to him. He examined the picture again. The two of them in bed, her legs wrapped around Cole's hips, her heels in his rump. The light came from behind; it was midday. It was dim, like there was a storm. The picture was taken from near Jessie's bed and he tried to fathom how they'd managed it. Was it placed on a shelf, on one of Jessie's art projects? They must have set a timer.

After five minutes had passed, he began to imagine she had another boy in there with her. That Cole brought one of his lacrosse buddies to tag team her and sweet and gullible Maggie said, *Okay, that sounds like fun*. They took turns fucking her ass and her pussy and laughing and taking pictures. Just like that, his stomach turned rotten and curled inward like a suppurating post-Halloween pumpkin. He belched in his throat and felt bile splash up. That was crazy. She wouldn't do that, would she? He was having

trouble rectifying the real Maggie with the Maggie he had painted for her brother. She wasn't really that wanton, was she? It would kill him if she did that. Two guys at once and he wasn't one of them? He felt his brow lower and his eyes well with sadness. He couldn't wait to be home.

Then, on cue:

Maggie: Can't wait to see you. want you here with me

She ignored the question of the photographer and he wouldn't ask again. Not till he was home. He rested his hand on his own heart and felt his chest and neck shaking with its powerful beats.

Max: I'll be home soon. we'll go do something fun mon night

She texted him another happy face emoji, followed by a few hearts. A minute later she resumed with:

Maggie: how are your folks? did you say hi from me?

He hung his head with sad shame. He forgot he was up to his own nonsense today and now he had to lie.

Max: of course

Maggie: what did you do today?

Max: nothing

Maggie: you guys go out?

Max: yeah

He grumbled and ran his hands through his hair, hating that he would lie to her like this.

Maggie: are they around? wanna skype?

Max: they're out back maybe later

Enormous guilt fell over him now. Why did he want to manipulate her? She was perfect.

Before any more questions came he texted:

Max: hey gotta go ttyl heading out for dinner

He set his phone down and hated himself. He'd come out here to perform an illegitimate task, but it was for the greater good. But he was so fucking deceitful. When did it get like this? Why wouldn't honesty with Maggie be the path he took? What would make him think that, however noble the cause, lying to his fiancée and attempting manipulations behind her back was acceptable?

Under it all, he realized he must be hurting. It was the only thing that made sense. As much as he loved to see her with Cole and sometimes Jay, as much as he put up a brave face and told her to experiment, he was hurting himself. And it wasn't necessarily that she was having sex with these guys. That wasn't bad. He liked it. It aroused him. Cole's closeness wasn't Maggie's fault.

There was something else tugging at him and he couldn't see its face yet. He worried that when he saw its face, it would be his own, like looking in a mirror. The problem he had was his own lies. Maggie was happy, but she'd been tricked into this. Was she tricked into liking it? How much did she actually like this? When she tired of fucking these other hot guys would she see her Max the same way? When all the hot-blooded passion was exhausted, and she looked around her would she turn her nose up at the activities spurred by the boy she was supposed to marry? Wouldn't then a guy like Cole just take her hand and walk away with her? If that were to happen it would be his own damn fault. And it wasn't the sex with Cole that

would separate them, it would be his own amateur Machiavellian scheming. He was hurting her. That's what was wrong. His lies, his manipulations. He was hurting her, and she didn't even know it.

His thumbs flashed on the screen and in a few minutes he had changed his open-ended ticket, booking a flight home first thing in the morning. Save himself another two-fifty on the hotel room by going home. What was the point anyway? ...why keep up the ruse he was staying with his folks if he was going to come clean?

He would see Maggie by lunch time tomorrow and maybe he would sit with her and begin to relate to her the truth. As soon as the decision had been made, he felt better. Now he couldn't wait to tell her the truth. Never felt closer to her suddenly. They'd shared so much as a couple in the last few weeks, grown in crazy ways but they were still one unit. Everything up till now had been fun. If he was honest with her, the closeness with Cole would dissipate. He was her true other, not Cole. She could still fuck him if he was honest. He could picture himself telling her the truths and she was mad at him, but soon they were giggling and rolling on the bed.

Of course, he saw his meeting with Ken going better, too—he might be bad at imagining. There was a danger still lurking that she may have trouble facing: a video most likely did exist, and it wasn't her brother who hid it. Then again, sometimes those things really did just shit the bed.

Tomorrow would be a new day, and to celebrate he lay on the bed and flipped through the menu. With the money saved on the canceled night in the hotel he splurged a little and ordered a New York strip and a baked potato, and a bottle of beer. As he waited he considered only one possible concern: Ken calling Maggie tonight and spilling the beans before he could talk to her tomorrow. He would be as truthful as he could with her, softening the edges of some of the more nefarious of his schemings, but if Ken leaked it first, he would have a much tougher time.

Before his meal arrived, his phone buzzed again with an incoming text.

Maggie: I have another picture but it's really bad, you don't want to see it

His stomach tightened with dread. What would be so bad? He pictured a close up of Cole's cock sliding inside her and his fingers twitched and his

palms sweated.

Max: yes I do

After an agonizing delay which he was sure she was doing on purpose, she answered:

Maggie: You sure?

Max: I'm sure

Maggie: It's really bad. You have to say please

She had his full attention. He answered.

Max: Please

Maggie: I warned you

Room service had terrible timing and while he waited they knocked on the door. He held for a moment, watching the screen of his phone and waiting. They knocked again.

"Fuck," he whispered and set his phone face down on the bed, answered, ushered the young server in and tipped him, got him the heck out of there. When he was alone again, he stood by the bed and looked at the backside of his phone as it lay on the crisp comforter. His palms were wet with worry and he wriggled his fingers in anticipation. The steak smelled delicious.

When he was prepared, he flipped it over and swiped his phone back to life. He lost his appetite.

Best Man

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 21ST

MAGGIE LAY between Cole's open legs with her back against his chest, his penis against her rump; she rose and fell on his breathing.

She said, "I'm glad I couldn't hold out."

After a moment, Cole said, "Me, too."

He kissed the back of her neck, gathered up her hair into a ponytail held in a fist, kissed the soft hairs behind her ears, sucked on an earlobe and got her groaning again, her nipples hardening so abruptly she put her hands over to cover them.

"Ow," she laughed.

"What?"

"My nipples got hard so fast it hurt."

"That's your other special spot."

"Other special spot?"

"You have another one."

"Oh, yeah, I do," she said warily.

His hand slipped down her naked waist, got her trembling and jittering, knowing where it headed.

"Don't," she laughed, her declaration breaking up.

"Here it is," he said, and he ran the backs of his fingers over her haunch and up the underside of her thigh where it met her ass cheek. It drove a squirrely tornado through her, making her jump, but he hugged her firmly.

"Don't," she laughed again, still jumping in his clutch. He stopped, smoothing to the front of her thighs, squeezing her knee, groaning appreciatively in her ear as he held her.

“You hungry? he whispered to her, and she nodded.

It was dim now outside, the sun going down. The storm had raged but dissipated, leaving only a pattering of rainfall, the wind dying down to a breeze.

He said, “Let me go get dinner. You stay here.”

“You don’t want to go out together?”

“I do not want to go out. I want to go pick up dinner, grab some beers, bring it all here, we’ll pig out on this bed.”

“And then?” she smiled and caressed the back of his hand.

“I’m going to spend all night in here. I think we chased Jessie away.”

“Oh, no,” she groaned and hid her face in her hands. “I can’t believe I let her see us like that ...”

He shushed her, shaking her in his arms. He said, “Don’t. It’s okay. It’s not crazy. We’re in a three-way relationship. You think we’re the only ones she knows like that? All those weird theatre friends of hers in Brattleboro?”

She giggled in his arms feeling lighter from his words. “You think so?” she said. “God, I asked her to take that picture ... what was I thinking? ... It was just so crazy in the moment.”

“It’ll be okay, I swear it. What she saw today would be the tenth weirdest relationship she knows.”

She said, “A three-way relationship? Is that what we are? A threesome?”

“I think it’s pretty clear we are.”

She whispered, “I think I really like that,” and she leaned back so her crown rested in the hollow of his neck, turned, eyes up to his, desperate for his kiss. He dipped his head and took her mouth and kissed her lovingly while her hand stroked his cheek. Right now all she wanted was Max to be home. Max to be okay with this. To be a part of it. The threesome.

But more importantly, she wanted pizza, she wanted beer, and she wanted to spend the rest of the night between the sheets with the hottest guy she knew.

“Go get dinner,” she whispered. “I want you back here in my bed in half an hour.”

“Yeah, I’m starving,” he said, and he kissed the backside of her ear before slipping out from behind her and standing naked at the side of the bed. She watched his muscular back and perfect boy ass as he gathered up his shorts and put his legs into them.

“Shit,” he said.

“What?”

“I used my sweatshirt to dry your face.”

“Max has some things in my bottom drawer.”

Now she watched him as he pulled the drawer open, the muscles of his tanned arms working, running his beautiful hair from his face. He tugged a T-shirt on and it was tight. The sweatshirt was the same.

“Little tight, huh?” she giggled.

“It’ll work,” he said, then peeked out her window. “Stopped raining I think. Or it’s just light,” he said. “What pizza do you want?”

“Um, white with pepperoni. You’re going to bring Altieri’s here?”

“I’m going to bring it here and we can eat it naked in bed.”

“Hurry back,” she said.

He checked he had his wallet and his phone, came in for a kiss, then went to the door. Then out of the blue, he stopped and said, “We’re a threesome until I decide I don’t want to share anymore.” He winked and smiled.

She giggled. “You’re such a bad boy.”

He closed the door and left to go get their dinner.

FIRST THING she thought when the door opened behind her was to show Cole the T-shirt she wore. Lacrosse written across the front, Cole would want to see her wearing it. Face down on the bed, LSAT prep guide open in the middle, two halves bowed like bird wings, elbows dug into the mattress, she crossed her hands over her chest and covered the shirt as she turned, ready for a reveal. Only it wasn’t Cole. In the doorway of her room, clothes dampened by rain, face pursed in harrowing bewilderment, stood Jay Carmichael. The boy whose shirt she once wore.

Her mouth opened as if to speak but no words came out—she couldn’t comprehend what he was doing there nor did she want to. Everything in his demeanor frightened her.

“Maggie,” he said, his voice a dry crackle, weak and injured. He closed the door behind him.

“Jay, what are you doing here? You can’t—”

“What are *you* doing here?” he hissed.

She saw the anger on his face—a chill up her back, reassessing it now as rage—and she suddenly felt very vulnerable. Alone in her closed dorm room, she wore only a T-shirt, no panties. She drew her legs up. “Jay, please leave,” she whispered, shocked at how small her voice sounded.

“You’re fucking that guy now?” he spat.

“No, Jay, it’s—”

“You lying bitch—I was outside. I’ve been outside the ... what a piece of trash you are ...” he said, and he stalked toward the bed.

“Jay, please ...”

“Got your new boyfriend to come talk for you, tell me all that bullshit?”

She backed herself farther up the bed, wanting instead to race around him and get out of her room, but afraid he would grab her and her running would set off some predatorial instinct. “Look, Jay, I’d like you to—”

“You fuck around on your fiancé with me. Now you’re fucking around behind my back. Fucking the Best Man? Is he?”

“Is he what?”

“The best man?”

“Yeah, he’s the Best Man ...”

He sneered, “How fucking low are you?”

“Jay, please, don’t—”

He stepped closer, hunched over and menacing. She began to tremble. “What a piece of shit you are. Just a fucking whore. Low life slut. I can’t believe I loved you.”

It was the honest venom from him—mixed with a tightening fear—that brought her tears. His words were horrid. She never had anyone mad at her in her entire life. Her whole body trembled, her back spasmed, her legs jumped. Her eyes welled suddenly and completely and she began to bawl.

“Fucking crybaby,” he spat and lunged closer, big hands balled into fists. She put her hands up to protect herself and he grabbed her wrists and yanked her to the edge of the bed.

“Ow,” she cried and fell to her side, hiding her face from him.

“Look at me,” he hissed, and he sat her up by her neck.

Through warbled, tear-stained vision she saw the hate in his gray eyes and she felt an urge for her bladder to release. “Please, don’t hurt me,” she squeaked.

His eyes drifted low, and he saw her shirt.

“And I fucking loved you,” he murmured.

“How?” she cried. “We’ve only known ea—”

“I know,” he said. “How could I? Look at you ...” his eyes went up and down her like she was disgusting road kill, his lips snarled and nostrils flared. “Fucking lacrosse. You love that pretty-boy fuck?”

“No,” she cried weakly.

“You’ll just fuck anything,” he grunted and rose above her. She put her hands up again, but he reached around them and grabbed the shoulders of Cole’s shirt and he yanked it hard enough to lift her off the bed.

He tugged and wrenched and she resisted but in the end she lifted her arms and he pulled it right off her, turning it inside out. She was completely naked now, and she began to wail.

“Shut the fuck up,” he hissed.

She swallowed it, lay on her side, her hands covering her breasts and watched as he stood and tried to rip the T-shirt in two. He struggled and strained to the point it was comical, and if she wasn’t convinced he was going to harm her, she might laugh. He got it then, and the shirt came apart easily and he threw it on to Jessie’s bed.

“Please, Jay,” she whispered. “Please, don’t hurt me.” She cowered on the bed underneath him, her cheek pressed to the sheets.

His voice was calmer now, he said, “Hurt you? I don’t even want to touch you. You’re disgusting.”

“He’ll be back soon. You have to go.”

“Think I’m afraid of him? Maybe I’ll sit here with you and when he comes in, we’ll see what he does. I’ll twist his head right off his fucking body. You want that? Huh, you want that? Then you can be responsible for fucking up yet another man’s life, you cocksucking whore.”

“I’m sorry, Jay,” she whispered.

“Sorry,” he scoffed then sat on the bed, his back to her.

She thought to put a hand to him, lay it on his back to calm him down but pictured it then having the opposite effect, so she kept her arms folded up across her chest, laying on her side with her knees drawn up.

He looked over his shoulder and down at her and she saw his eyes gleamed wet. His expression was softer, his eyes less mean. He got closer to her, and she recoiled. He persisted, moving his face to hers and then kissing her cheek while she held her breath and shut her eyes tightly.

“How can you want to hurt me, Maggie?” he whispered.

“I’m sorry,” she breathed.

“I’m not going to hurt you.”

“Can you ... can you please go?”

“Don’t you think we had something? We had fun ...”

“Yeah,” she sighed, her vision warbling with tears.

“We had something, Maggie. You meant something ...”

He turned away from her again, hands on the bed on either side of her raised legs, twisted at the waist, hanging his head and hiding his face from hers.

He sat like that for a long while and she was frozen.

He shook his head and cleared his throat.

“Please, Jay,” she whispered, “Please just go. You’re scaring me.”

He huffed and shook his head, he raised his eyes to hers and she scrunched hers closed. “What’s this?” he grunted.

When she opened her eyes, she saw him looking over her to the wall next to the bed. She darted a look behind, saw the drawing she’d done of Cole and had pinned there.

Jay reached across and she grabbed his arm and hugged it. “Wait, no please, no ...”

“You fucking drawing him now?”

She clutched his arm, but he reached with the other and snatched it off the pin, tearing a line across the top.

“Oh, please, please, Jay, seriously, don’t, okay?” Her voice was frantic, and she darted up onto her knees.

He put a hand on her collar, keeping her back while he examined the drawing, holding it in the other hand. When she reached to gently take it he pushed on her neck and she clutched her hands to her bare breasts again.

His mouth took a firm line, his plump lips flattening and then turning down as he looked at her sexy and sleazy drawing of the boy who she was sure right now she loved though didn’t want to admit it. All she wanted was to live another day so she could tell him.

“Please, Jay,” she said softly, and she pressed her palms together in the attitude of prayer and wagged them as she pleaded: “Jay, I’m begging you ... please, give me back my drawing ... Jay ...?”

“I fucking hate you,” he muttered. Then he tore the drawing once down the middle and she shrieked.

“Jay, no, please, don’t ...” She lunged to retrieve it but he moved away and he tore it again, taking the two halves and tearing them into four pieces

now.

The tears streamed from her again as she sat and futilely watched Jay take that magic moment, that wonderful and beautiful treasure she had created with Cole today, and destroyed it forever. He tore it into increasingly smaller strips. She clutched her hands to her face and cried into them, sobbing and wailing.

Jay shoved her, and she rolled onto her back, drew her knees up, ankles crossing to cover her sex. He got over her, his legs straddling her hips, knees pressed down in the bedding on either side of her. He wrestled her hands away from her face and when she looked at him, he showered her with the confetti of the drawing.

She whispered, "Please, please, don't hurt me, Jay ... please ..."

Crater

SUNDAY, OCTOBER 22ND

WHILE HIS PLANE arrived in Albany at 11 A.M., he had to wait until 1:30 before the Greyhound departed. It arrived in Farmingham at ten after three, dumping him in a Park-and-Ride lot behind the Mt. Victor's Masonic Lodge, where he cut across the curb that separated the lot from a Fast Lube, turned left onto Main Street and at the sight of Altieri's he felt at home.

He went straight to his dorm, looking to change then run over and surprise Maggie (even if she was with Cole, he didn't mind, wanted to see him, too).

Sure, last night he'd had difficulty accepting the picture she'd sent him. Her chin turned up, a close-up of her mouth, Cole's semen pooling in her philtrum, blocking a nostril and streaming her pretty skin. He ate the steak. Not right away, it took some getting adjusted to the revelation of that lubricious image. Then he pushed it out of his mind, watched TV, lay in bed but couldn't get to sleep. He tossed and turned a bit and a little after one, despite how disgusted he was by the picture, and how tender the head of his penis was, he masturbated under the covers while looking at it and then finally he got to sleep.

He'd focused on the moment before the picture was taken; how did it come to this, who suggested it? He wouldn't be surprised if it was something his fiancée would ask for. Though it was something a guy might try to coerce a girl to accept he didn't think, given the breakfast at Denny's and Cole's demeanor, that he would ask that of their Maggie. It led him to think that his sweet but surprisingly dirty girlfriend requested it. That uncomfortable thought, while thrilling, came with the imagining of them

together without him, laughing and enjoying each other's company without the third member of the troika. It was jealousy, sexual arousal, isolation, and abandonment, all together for a pointed and magnificent pang that he hated to enjoy.

When he arrived at his dorm room, 312 Samuelson, he found his roommate Steve alone, studying at his desk. Max entered, and though he'd only been gone a day and a half it felt much longer. Steve half-turned, back hunched at his laptop, his eyes blinking behind his glasses, his face expressionless.

"Hey man," Max said.

"You're back early," Steve said.

"Yeah, I booked an earlier flight. I like my parents and all, but you know..."

"I heard that," he said in a low, careful and even tone.

Max threw his bag on the bed, knew he would unpack later—right now he just wanted to get comfortable clothes on and get his way to Keegan as quickly as he could. He rifled through his closet, pulled off his shirt and put on a sweater. A lot colder in Vermont than in San Diego. When he turned, headed to the dresser to retrieve pants, he found Steve still staring at him. He sat with his elbows on the arms of his swivel chair, a cursor blinking behind him, halfway through a term paper, and he regarded Max with that strange expressionless face, eyes still blinking behind glasses.

"What's up?" he said, sensing there was something.

Steve slowly inhaled, eyes rolling to the ceiling a bit, he swiveled in the chair. Resolve gathered, he leaned forward again, put his elbows on his knees now and clasped his hands.

Max took out a pair of pants from his dresser, let them unfold and drape over an arm as he sat on the bed across from Steve. He waited.

Steve still said nothing, and it was obvious something needed to be broached. Max prompted him again: "What's going on?"

Steve's eyes came up to regard him and Max saw that they were troubled. He went to speak, paused, chewed briefly on the corner of his lip then said: "You were away, right?"

"Yeah, you know that ..."

"No, I know that, I just mean ... You were out of town."

"Right ..."

"Well, my brother hangs out with this guy at Keegan ..."

“Yeah, I know. I see him hanging out there.”

“Yeah, well he hangs out there, and ...” He paused, scratched the back of his neck, winced at what he had to say, then continued. “Yeah, my brother was there, and he was on the second floor. You know, where Maggie is ...”

“I know.”

“Yeah, well he was there, hanging out on the couches there, you know where they are,” and he paused again, then said, “and you know your friend Cole ...”

“I know,” he said and now he knew where this was going.

“Well,” he said, “he was in there with Maggie.”

“They’re studying for her LSAT,” he said quietly.

“Okay,” he said. “But my brother said he was in there all day. Now, maybe he shouldn’t have done this, but he thought it was weird and I guess he likes you or whatever because he knows you’re my roommate, and well, he went closer, you know, to the door ...”

“And ...?”

“You know ...”

He felt the heaviness now, knew what had happened in that room, had seen photographic evidence, and knew that his roommate and his brother had been talking about it. He said, “He heard something?”

“He did. He heard them ...”

“What did he hear?”

Steve shrugged and gave him a pained expression, indicating it should be obvious and he needn’t say.

Max said, “He heard sounds?”

“He did. He heard them doing things in there.”

He debated just admitting it. Thought maybe it was time to just say *Yeah, he probably heard them having sex. I know what they do and I’m okay with it.* But maybe he wasn’t ready for the next step. The next step for him right now, his nerve building up on the hour-and-a-half Greyhound, was getting to Maggie and sitting with her and being truthful for once.

“Okay, I hear you. Thanks for telling me.”

“Is that okay?”

“That you told me? Yeah, you did the right thing. But you should know, it’s okay.”

“It’s okay?”

“No, I just mean that I’m glad you told me, and everything about it is going to be cool. You know what I mean?”

“No.”

“That I’m not upset. My feelings aren’t hurt. It’s not necessarily bad news.”

“It’s not?”

He shrugged, not wanting to be truthful with Steve, and not knowing how best to phrase this nor necessarily wanting to put the effort into it.

He stood up again, and squeezed Steve’s shoulder, said, “Thanks for telling me. I mean it. That must’ve been hard.”

“Yeah, it was.”

Max undid his pants and slipped on his jeans, discarded his loafers in exchange for sneakers. He threw on his peacoat while Steve watched him.

He said, “I’m going to see her right now. Would you believe me if I told you nothing’s changed? ... between her and I ...”

Steve shrugged, his face still expressionless but his eyes wider, trying to understand.

He said, “Thanks again. I’ll see you.”

THIS WAS way bigger than him, bigger than he could handle. How did he think he could control his Maggie like this? How did he think he had the power over her to manage her heart? He’d been so manipulative, shaping her into his fantasies, using the natural will of her own sexual curiosity to help her shape his perfect vagary. Only now it was ruined, the armature of their relationship exposed, the love and friendship and sanctity denuded, leaving bare jagged branches. Hopefully strong enough to survive a harsh winter, hopefully strong enough to bloom in spring.

Roommate Steve’s little brother was nowhere to be seen out front of Keegan. Probably for the better, Max was unsure how their eyes would meet. He trotted up the steps into the old hall, dashed the stairwell to the second floor, hesitated at the door to 204. Listened for a moment, hoping to hear a sonata, Boccherini, cello and bass. Heard nothing but a steady rasping whisper.

He knocked on the door and waited. The sound stopped and a girl's voice, not Maggie's, said, "Come in."

He twisted the lever and stepped into Maggie's room and saw only Jessie. She was on her side of the room, amid the clutter of her found objects wearing overalls with a red T-shirt underneath and welding without a mask.

He said, "You supposed to do that in here?"

She said, "It's just a touch up. Hi, Max." She shut off the torch and set it on the floor.

Maggie's bed was unmade, littered with paper. Some of her drawers were open, and he saw that they were empty.

He said to Jessie, "Is Maggie around?"

Her posture was weak and her head hung low, she set herself on her bed and clasped her hands together between her knees. "No," she said, "I don't know where she is."

"When did you see her last?"

She shrugged, said, "Yesterday. In the afternoon."

He stepped in the room, stood at the side of Maggie's bed, looking out the window hoping he would see her walking one of the trails toward Keegan. He'd hoped to surprise her and didn't want to do it by text.

He put a knee on her bed, picked up a scrap of torn paper and saw pastel on one side. Like it was a drawing that had been ripped up. It made him feel a little cold inside. Something about the room, something about the energy in here. When he lifted his head, he saw it.

"What happened here?" he asked Jessie.

She shrugged her shoulders as he crossed back to the door. Just to the left of it someone had punched the wall, putting a fist-sized hole in the drywall.

"What was she doing yesterday?" he asked her.

Jessie breathed a moment, lifted her face toward him but her eyes darted to the right, afraid to meet his. "I don't know. She was here with Cole."

"Were they getting along?" he asked, turning, brow lowered with puzzlement as his finger traced around the jagged, chalky hole.

"They were getting along," she said.

"And you don't know how this happened?" he asked, tapping under the hole in the wall.

"No, I don't."

“You okay?”

Jessie said, “Me? Yeah, I’m okay. You’re home early.”

He murmured, “Yeah, I love my parents and all but, you know ...”

She nodded, and her gaze lowered to the floor.

In that simple movement of her head he saw a measurement of shame and it hit him that she could be the one who took the picture. He wanted to squirm right out of his skin. All that thought about how he was okay with this just spurting out of his grip. He wasn’t okay with it. Didn’t want others to know Maggie was shared. Didn’t want Jessie to know Maggie slept with Cole. He wanted sanctity again, he wanted Maggie all to himself. Of course it was all too late for that. From her face he could tell she knew. She’d seen them together, hadn’t she? Fuck, his heart sunk at the thought that she was the one who took the picture of her roommate fucking her fiancé’s best friend.

“Okay, I guess I’ll see you around. I’ll track her down, maybe she’s at Altieri’s ...”

He left Jessie sitting on the bed, her hands still between her knees, and went into the hall. He fished his phone from his pocket and texted Maggie:

Max: Hey where are you?

It wasn’t until he made it out to the path again that his phone binged.

Maggie: Hey man, it’s Cole when u back?

Max: I’m home now. I was just in Maggie’s room

Maggie: You better get here. Come to the Twilight Motel. in town - you know it?

He stood in the gray breeze, cold and chilly now, all that early October warmth leached from it and his skin missed the warmth of California. He felt a chill deep inside, too. A motel?

Max: Why what happened?

Twilight

SUNDAY, OCTOBER 22ND

MAX WALKED BRISKLY through the main street village, passing by Altieri's, the Masonic Lodge, and the Rapid Lube. Once past the village there was a stretch of wide-lawned homes that were hundreds of years old, and up ahead was where Cole told him to meet. Not the Twilight Motel but more accurately the Twilight Motor Inn. He passed right by it in the Greyhound this afternoon. Had he looked to the right, he would've seen Cole's lifted Jeep parked out front.

He walked up the paved entrance, passing underneath the back-lit sign with scrolled cap that mimicked the shape of a tricorne revolutionary hat. Below it, 'vacancy' in the neon-tube 'no vacancy' sign flickered. Ahead was the motel, Cole's Jeep parked there and a few other vehicles on angles below it. It was set on a hill, close to the road, facing toward the Green Mountains. Two stories, colonial style with black slate roof, the trim, balconies, and stairways done in white-painted wood. The second floor balcony was hung with star-spangled bunting.

His pace quickened, worry accelerating him. Cole hadn't responded with what happened. Max texted: *Why is there a hole in the wall?* No response. He texted: *Is Maggie okay?* No response. The only thing Cole said was: *We're in Room 7.* And that's where he headed now, his shoes clapping along the asphalt, jumping the two brick-paved steps onto the wooden first floor balcony. He dashed to Room 7, and the door opened before he got there.

Cole backed out onto the glossy gray-painted wood balcony and closed the motel room door behind him. He wore a sweatshirt and jeans, coming

out in his socks.

Max said, “Cole, what the fuck? ...”

Cole said nothing but came and embraced him, enfolded Max in his arms and hugged him tight, he exhaled in Max’s ear: “So fucking glad you’re home, dude.”

“What the fuck is going on?” Max said, patting Cole’s back.

Cole grabbed him by the arms and said, “That fucking guy ... that fucking Jay Carmichael, dude ...”

“What ... what happened?”

“He fucking ...”

“Holy shit,” Max gasped, “where’s Maggie?”

“She’s fine, she’s fine, Max, she’s sleeping,” Cole said, holding Max’s forearm as he reached for the door. “Just let her sleep, dude, she had a hard time getting to sleep.”

“She’s okay? Cole, what happened to her?”

“She’s fine. She says she’s fine. That guy came into her dorm room ... I wasn’t there... And he ...”

“Jesus, he what? ... Did he hurt her?”

“I don’t know. She doesn’t want to talk about it.”

“Did he fucking hurt her?” he hissed angrily at Cole.

Cole gripped his arms tighter. “She said he didn’t.”

Max wrestled from Cole’s grip and went to the door. Cole grabbed him again, said, “You have to let her sleep ...”

But Max pulled from Cole’s grip, disregarded him; there was no way he couldn’t be with her. He opened the door, charged into the hotel room, the shades drawn, the room dim. There was a lone double bed in the room and Maggie lay underneath a paisley comforter, her beautiful shape bumping out its garish pattern.

It hurt him to see that they had slept together, could see where Cole had been laying next to her but he shook it off. He was across the room in a second, and kneeling on the bed. Maggie’s eyes fluttered, and he put a hand on her shoulder. Her eyes opened, blinked, focused.

“Oh, my God, Max! Oh, Max, Max, Max,” she exhaled and scrambled out from under the comforter, embraced him hard. He squeezed her back even harder. She wore sweatpants and socks and a sweatshirt with the hood cowed around her neck. Her hair was unwashed, but he loved its smell, loved the way it tangled under his nose.

“I love you so much. I love you so much, Maggie.”

“I love you, Max,” she cried and crushed him.

Cole came in the room and closed the door, walked to the foot of the bed where there were two wicker chairs and he sat in one, making it creak. Max watched over Maggie’s shoulder as Cole regarded them blankly. He gave Cole a nod, then whispered to Maggie: “Tell me what happened.”

She ignored him, her arms slinking around him, elbows dipping down to his waist and her nails scratching at his back.

“Maggie, what happened?”

“Nothing,” she whispered. “Why are you home? What day is it?”

“It’s Sunday, Maggie. I came home early. I missed you. I told you that—I told you I missed—”

“I missed you too, Max. I missed you so much. How are your parents?”

“My pare—? ... we’ll talk about them later. You swear you’re okay?”

“I’m okay,” she squeaked then buried her face in his neck.

Max took her face in a palm and caressed her cheek with his thumb, gently guided her face away so he could look in her eyes. She did for a moment but then closed them. “Maggie,” he whispered, “did he touch you?”

Her plump lips trembled, parted, and she hesitated, a croak in her throat, but finally she said, “No.”

“What did he do?”

But now he lost her, and he saw her hand over his shoulder waving Cole to join them. Cole eased up off the creaky chair, got on his knees on the bed and walked toward them. Max let him in, let Maggie part from him, but kept a hold of her wrist. Cole got behind her, on the other side, and eased Maggie to lay back in the pillows with him. Max fell to her side as well.

Cole put an arm around her and held her, Max gripped her wrist, wriggled himself as close to her as he could, cupped his hand on her neck and ran his thumb along her jaw. Eventually she fell asleep again.

“A TWELVE-INCH ASSORTED on whole wheat, six-inch grilled chicken breast on whole wheat, and a twelve-inch roast beef and ham on white.”

The guy behind the counter nodded, turned to the stainless steel shelves of the baking unit and retrieved the bread. Max turned and put his rump against the counter, folded his arms and looked out the window of the Subway, across the street and up the grassy expanse that lay below the Twilight Motor Inn. Saw Cole's Jeep parked up close, and the door, Room 7, and imagined the troubles behind it.

He'd gone all that way to San Diego and left the woman who was to be his wife alone. For what? *For nothing*. Left her with a friend, left her in the arms of another man. Could never have anticipated what actually transpired. He always knew there was something dark about Jay Carmichael.

He paid for the subs, gathered them in a plastic bag with their drinks, crossed the quiet Main Street in the dark up to the lights of the motel. He stepped up to the first balcony and found Cole leaning over the railing waiting for him. He went to his side, murmured, "Hey."

Cole's gaze still traveled up, looking across the street over the Subway and a Main Street plaza to the Green Mountains beyond. His phone vibrated in his hand and he tilted the screen to read it.

Max hoisted the bag with their dinner for Cole to see, nodded toward the motel room door.

Cole said, "I got four guys, we're driving up to Brattleboro tonight and we're going to tune this fucker up."

"What?"

"We have room for one more. You in?"

Max said, "Are you crazy? You can't do that. You'll get expelled. Fuck, go to jail."

"Max, he fucking hurt her. Look at her," he said, now thrusting his head toward the door. "You going to let him do that?"

"Does Maggie know? Did you tell her?"

"No, she doesn't know."

"I guarantee she doesn't want you to do that."

"I don't care, Max. He came in and assaulted her while she was naked. I was just there, Max. I was there, and I went to go get us dinner and that coward piece of shit comes in when I'm gone and he fucking ..." Cole's eyes went red and he teared up.

Max held his arm.

"... And he fucking ... he fucking hurt her, man."

Max said, "He didn't rape her ..."

"So? She says he didn't. But what if he did?"

Now Max's eyes welled up like Cole's. "Cole you can't do this."

Cole's phone buzzed again, and he went back to the railing and his thumbs danced out instructions to some of his other buddies, getting a posse together to do harm.

Max went back in the room. Maggie was sitting upright, bundled up and looking so small in her sweatshirt, her knees hidden underneath the comforter. There was a small LCD TV in the corner on a wood veneer stand and she watched Judge Judy with the sound low.

He said, "You know what he's thinking?"

"Who's thinking?" she mumbled. He tossed the subs and the pop cans onto one of the wicker chairs and got on the bed with her. Cole came in and closed the door behind him.

Max said, "He's going to Brattleboro with a bunch of guys to beat the shit out of Jay."

"Max, you fucking asshole," Cole said.

"He can't do that, Maggie."

Maggie's face looked angry but vacant. She said, "You can't do that, Cole."

Cole said, "That guy's fucking dead. He's fucking dead."

Maggie said, "Don't do that." Her voice was flat and distant.

Cole shook his head angrily, wanting to say so much but biting his tongue. He folded his arms and looked up to the corner of the ceiling.

Max got up and said, "Cole, he's not worth it. Dude, he's totally not worth it. He's a piece of shit."

Cole said, "Yeah, he is a piece of shit. Ask anybody that knows him. He's a fucking weirdo. You fucking made her sleep with him." Now his arms unfolded, his hands balled in fists at his sides.

Max put his hands up, said, "I didn't."

"You did. You fucking made her."

Max turned to Maggie said, "What did you tell him?"

Maggie shrugged, her gaze lost in the nothing between Max and Cole, and Judge Judy. She murmured, "You don't do anything. Don't do a thing. I'm going to take care of it."

Cole said, "Maggie, I'm going to handle it."

Maggie said, “No. You put me here. All you guys. I did too. I’m going to get myself out of this. I don’t need your help.”

Max said, “Maggie ...? You need us. We shouldn’t do anything to Jay. Not physically, but ...”

Cole walked between the wicker chairs and grabbed his keys off the table, threw up his hands and said, “Fuck this.”

As he turned to leave, Max grabbed his arm and stopped him. “Cole, she doesn’t want you to—”

“What the fuck do you know what’s good for her? This is your fault.” He thrust an index finger into Max’s chest.

Max said, “It’s not my fault.”

“You’re so full of shit, Max. You’re so fucking full of shit. You wanted her to sleep with that guy. Didn’t even care who it was. Just wanted to watch your girlfriend get fucked by another dude. Fucking pervert,” and now he abruptly shoved Max, both hands pushing on his shoulders and knocking him back a step.

But Max was unfazed, instead of being hurt by his words and his lack of understanding of what really went on Max stepped forward and launched back: “You just fucking want her for her money. You fucking drooled over all her father’s shit.”

Cole’s face startled. Hurt. But worse, Maggie gasped.

Max turned to her, and when Cole punched him in the stomach and it plunged all the air from his lungs and he fell on the floor, his mind was still frozen with the image of the pained look on Maggie’s face. That look that said Max thought Maggie wasn’t good enough for Cole. That a guy like Cole would only like her because she had rich parents. The single stupidest, most hurtful thing he could ever say. Aimed at Cole but it went off like a hand grenade in that room, hurting everybody, even himself.

When he tried to breathe in he couldn’t, just bellowed the sound of a dying buffalo on the plains. Then Maggie was on his back, putting her arms around him, Cole’s strong hand wrapping around his upper arm and the two of them helping him to the bed.

He collapsed on it, his chest struggling and twisting, desperate for air though none would come in. He was seized. Cole soothed him, ran his hand in a circle between Max’s shoulder blades, saying, “Sorry, dude, I’m so sorry.”

He wanted to say *Fuck off*, but he couldn't say a thing; couldn't breathe in nor out. His mind panicked, thinking this was how he would die. On the bed between a girl who once loved him, now loved another, her new boyfriend killing him accidentally after he said something so hurtful to her.

He gasped and bucked, his mind reeling with endorphins as the first sign of release came, the muscles in his back relaxing just the slightest, cool disinfected motel room air slowly squeaking through his airways like the nipple of a balloon.

He caught a glimpse of his face in the mirror at the foot of the bed, saw Maggie worriedly bracing two hands on his shoulders, Cole with one foot on the floor, one knee on the bed, his hand massaging his back. Saw his wild red eyes, his blubbering lips, saw the panic in his expression.

Maggie told Cole, "Get out of here."

Cole said, "Maggie, I'm sorry ..."

"You have to get out of here. I don't want to even look at you right now."

Then Cole was up on the bed, on his knees, sitting on his heels. He had both his hands out to Maggie, and he said, "Maggie, don't say that. I'm sorry. I am *really* sorry."

But now Maggie was crying, falling forward and putting her arms around Max, Max witnessing the whole thing playing out through his warbled vision in the mirror.

She sobbed, "Just get out of here. I'm so tired. So tired of everybody. I just want to be alone."

Max inhaled the word "Maggie," a rasping croak, desperate to hear her take that back.

She left both of them, crawled up the bed and curled up in the pillows. Cole slowly stepped off the bed and stood at the foot. Max looked at him and they stared into each other's eyes, no animosity just worry. He stepped back and turned to the door, went outside.

Now he was alone with Maggie, his breath returning, and he crawled to her. He got behind her and caressed her shoulder. Without looking at him she whispered, "Tell him to come back."

And though he wanted to be alone with her, he knew they shouldn't let him leave. Just for the sake that it might prevent his best friend from going and doing something crazy. Maybe Cole would end up with his head broken open on the sidewalk, or choked to death in Jay's headlock. Or him and four

guys accidentally killing Jay Carmichael outside a bar in Brattleboro. Going to jail, ruining their lives.

Maybe Max would go to jail. Not for violence, but when an investigation turned up his perversion. Didn't know what the laws were against that in Vermont, but he knew that he did feel guilty now. All the truths he wanted to tell this beautiful girl had to be bottled up again, zipped up tight and hidden from sunlight. He did trick her into sleeping with Jay. She may never have done it on her own. Though it may have seemed to him that she would, there was no saying she would do it on her own. She was a sweet girl, and he coerced her. It was likely she could have seen through Jay's strange game alone in her dorm room before it was too late, once her hormones had settled. Maybe told Jay not to come back anymore, or maybe went to a proper studio space to draw him. Max was the one who pushed her in front of the train. And therefore he was the one who put her alone in a dorm room yesterday with Jay where he did something to her that she didn't want to talk about.

So he stood up, now duty-bound to this woman he loved, went to the door to try to stop Cole before he left. There was no fear, Cole was nowhere near his Jeep. He stood at the white wooden railing just outside the door with his elbows on it, hands clasped together watching the bruise colored sky above the mountains. As he walked behind him, Cole said, "Don't talk to me."

"Okay," Max said. "She said she wants you to come back. She doesn't want you to go."

He watched Cole as he gave no reaction, his thick blond hair hanging on his neck, bunched up by his broad, hunched shoulders. After a while, Cole said, "You okay?"

"I'll live," he said, feeling wet gurgling air in his throat, struggling to get to his lungs more easily. His stomach hurt all over, but it was condensing to a contracted locale the size of a fist right over his breadbasket.

"Okay. I'm coming back in."

Max waited but Cole didn't turn. He went back in the room and closed the door and got on the bed with Maggie. She lay with her head in the pillows, her knees drawn up and her hands hidden in the sleeves of her sweatshirt. He set himself down next to her and wriggled close so they were

face to face. He said, “He’s coming in,” and went to touch her face but chickened out and let it rest on her upper arm instead.

She said, “Max, you texted asking if I tied Cole up with my pink tights.”

“Yeah?”

“Was that because I tied Jay up with my pink tights?”

“Yeah.”

“How would you know I did that?”

He stared into her amber eyes and they darted back and forth over his. A cold chill worked up his back, condensing to an icy lump in the center of his forehead. He said, “I don’t know.”

“I know why you know.” She held his gaze for two heartbeats, her mouth in a grim line and then she rolled away, showed him her back.

The motel room door opened and closed and then Cole was crossing to the other side of the bed, slipping in next to Maggie and laying face to face with her. His hand held her waist, and he said, “It’s not true. What he said isn’t true.”

She whispered, “I know. I know it’s not, Cole.”

Security

MONDAY, OCTOBER 23RD

WHILE MAGGIE BLOW-DRIED her hair she watched Jessie in the mirror, laying on her bed and pretending to read. She was in her dorm room, walking back to campus after waking alone with Cole, showering here on the second floor, coming back to find Jessie awake now but not talking to her.

She brushed and blow-dried underneath her mane, working the fine hairs at the back of her neck. She applied some mousse and brushed her hair straight back from her face, revealing her sterner expression this morning. Stood and braided her hair, eyes flitting over her shoulder to watch Jessie toss and turn on the bed, rolling around and occasionally looking sideways at her. She got her hair tightly braided, curled in a bun at the back of her head. Applied some makeup. Not too much, just enough to highlight her important features. She dressed. Put on a black skirt, black leggings, black loafers. Oxford cloth button-down and then a cashmere sweater over top of that.

She liked what she saw in the mirror. This was no-nonsense. The highlights in her hair were gone. Underneath her clothes that shaggy muff she used to sport was shaved down and smooth. Things were a lot different than they were a month ago. She liked what she saw in the mirror. To the reflection over her shoulder she said, “You’re really not talking to me?”

Jessie was waiting for her to say something first because she no longer ignored her. Soon as Maggie spoke she dropped the book and sighed. A conversation had been working over in Jessie’s head and she couldn’t wait to talk about it.

Jessie said, "What makes you think I'm not talking to you?"

She turned, put an elbow on her dresser, said, "Jessie ... The fact that you're not talking to me."

Jessie sat up and tossed her book to the foot of her bed, said, "I know. I meant of course I'm not talking to you. Wouldn't you think that?"

"Sorry you walked in on that."

"I am, too."

"You know it's okay?"

"That's what you say."

"I'm telling you that it's okay."

"You're saying that Max knows? Seriously?"

"Max knows." She didn't say it quietly, she stated it as fact.

This was more perplexing to Jessie. Her eyes darted around the room and her head shook as she tried to say something. She wagged her hands with frustration. Finally she said, "You're engaged to Max."

"I am," she said as she crossed between the beds and sat on her own. Behind her still lay the scraps of paper where Jay had torn up her beautiful drawing. She smoothed her skirt and clasped her hands in her lap, facing Jessie.

Maggie kept her gaze and Jessie grew uncomfortable, finally saying, "I just never thought you were like that. I didn't think you were that kind of girl. I thought I knew you."

"I thought I knew me, too. I didn't think I was that kind of girl either. But here I am."

"Here you are," Jessie said and Maggie got the feeling she meant it as a defiant insult but it flopped. Jessie realizing, Maggie thought, that there really wasn't much for her to be mad about.

Maggie said, "I should've put the bandanna on the door. Cole and I hadn't intended for that to happen yesterday. I was studying."

"Yeah," Jessie said, rolling her eyes to the ceiling. Her body posture was relaxing, and she leaned back on her hands behind her.

"Max is good to me," Maggie said. "Cole is good to me, too."

Jessie said, "It's okay. I guess it's fine. You all know what you're doing, I just happened to walk in on it. And I'm having trouble dealing with it."

Maggie said, "I understand. I'm telling you nobody's getting hurt here."

Jessie inhaled, her wet eyes looking out the window at the gray morning sky. "Okay," she said.

No, Maggie, you never thought of yourself like that. She'd always seen girls like this growing up. When she was the wallflower who stood at the side of the room, the Asian girl who got perfect grades and went home to play her cello every night, she admired girls like this. Looked at them with wistful longing. To have so much power over others—boys, and even other girls—it was an incredible feeling. She never thought she would be this kind of girl. Now that it was here she wondered how long this girl had been living inside her.

Her phone buzzed in the pocket of her skirt and she excused herself from Jessie who nodded and bit her lower lip. She got off the bed because she didn't like the bed anymore anyway, stood, looked at the screen and saw the smiling face of her brother, his name superimposed below.

"Ken?" she whispered.

She slipped out of the room and walked into the quiet hall. There was a group of students gathered at the stairwell having a loud conversation, so she turned right and headed toward the couches where there was only one student reading quietly on an iPad. She leaned on the corkboard blazed with notices pinned to it. She answered, said, "Ken?"

"Hi, Maggie," she heard his tinny voice say.

Ken never called. Sometimes they would email but it wasn't often. Given yesterday's traumatic events, and the rift between her and Max she assumed that helpful Max had called her brother to let him know she'd been terrorized. She said, "What's going on?"

Ken said, "Just calling to see how you are."

"I'm fine," she said. "I'm doing great. How's it going in San Diego?"

"It's great, Maggie. Look, I know we don't usually talk, but I've been thinking about you."

"You have?"

"Yeah, I've been thinking about you a lot."

"I see. Did Max call you?"

There was a long pause, and she heard his cheek rub against the microphone. He said, "Max? No."

"Max didn't call you last night?"

"What would he call me about?"

"Never mind," she said, feeling an easiness spread through her shoulders. She said, "It's good to hear from you."

"I've heard about your postgrad endeavors."

“Carol talking to you?”

“Kind of. I think she’s proud of you. It’s more like bragging, but in the way that’s supposed to make me feel bad about myself.”

She giggled, covered her mouth, and her eyes teared up inexplicably. She said, “Sorry.”

“Don’t be sorry. I’m proud of you. It’s a little abrupt ...”

“I guess. I think it’s been lurking inside me for a long time.”

“Things are good with you and Max?”

“Yeah,” she said. “Things are good between me and Max.”

“I’m glad to hear that. I think your Max might be a good guy.”

“Yeah, my Max is a good guy. He’s got his problems ...”

“Hey,” he said.

“What?”

“This is kind of hard for me to say.”

“What is it?” she said, brow lowering. Ken never broached things that were difficult to say.

“Remember when we were at home two weeks ago?”

“Yeah, I do.”

“Yeah, I know ... I know you do. I’m just setting the scene.”

“Okay ...”

“Listen. I think the world of you. I think you’re awesome. And I love you.”

“I love you, too.”

“I saw you and Max and Cole together. In the music room.”

She winced, a stinging heat wave up her back and her neck, coming over her cheeks. She cupped a palm over her brow. “Hold on,” she whispered and she made her way to a couch across from the iPad reader and practically fell on it. Weakly, she said, “You did?”

“It’s okay. I kept it to myself.”

“I don’t know what to say, Ken.”

“Don’t say anything. I absolutely don’t want to talk about it. It’s why I called though.”

“Because you don’t want to talk about it?”

“I just want to make sure you’re doing the right thing.”

“I don’t know what to tell you—what right thing?”

“I want you to go to law school, Maggie. I want you to do it for the right reasons.”

“I’m going to law school for me, Ken. Nothing to do with mother, nothing to do with father, or anyone else for that matter.”

“Nothing to do with Cole?”

She hesitated, the silence drawing long and thin between them. She said, “I might not even go to Harvard.” Though she knew that was a lie.

Ken was quiet for a while too, then he quietly said. “That’s all I wanted to hear.”

She said, “Ken?”

“Yeah?”

“Did you ... after you saw us did you erase any videos?”

“The security system?”

“Did you?”

“What do you think?”

She nodded and ran her tongue over her molars. “Thank you,” she said.

Ken said, “Listen, Maggie, I have to get going. I got to meet some guys—”

She glanced at her watch, said, “Shoot, I have to go, too. I have an appointment.”

Ken said, “I want you to know that even though I don’t talk to you often, I think about you every day. You can call me anytime, maybe you and I should lean on each other a little bit more.”

“I’d like that,” she said.

“You take care. Say hi to Cole for me and give Max a hug, too. Tell him I called.”

“I will,” she whispered.

HER APPOINTMENT this morning was on the fourth floor of Winslow Hall. She’d taken the stairs and now passed the wide, spacious windows looking down over the soccer field. Players out there today kicking around balls in groups of four, dressed warmly but still in shorts. Then she was past those windows into the dim old corridor.

Straight ahead, where the hallway turned, she saw the black door to office 418. Under the number it read: PROF. CARMICHAEL. She opened the door without knocking and entered. It was a small office, the size of a

pantry, an elderly woman with red-rinsed hair and reading glasses on a bead-studded chain turned and said, “You’re Ms. Becker?”

Maggie approached the desk and told her that she was. The woman told her Professor Carmichael would just be a few more minutes.

She took a seat, eschewed the philosophy journals gathered under a table lamp at her elbow. Noted, though, that his name was featured on the covers. Her stomach began to twist again. All the resolve and power she’d woken with this morning starting to have second thoughts now. This was crazy. Crazy but it needed to be done and there was something in it that lit a spark—a couple of swipes of a striker knife over flint. A fire waiting to catch.

The truth was she should go to the police. But proving a crime was impossible. Was it a crime to be mad at your *girlfriend*? That’s what they would ask her. There was plenty of evidence that she had behaved in many ways that would make a man mad. Jay had technically committed no crime other than property damage. It wasn’t even her shirt he destroyed. *But the drawing ...? Oh, God, she wanted that drawing back so bad.* In the end, despite the enormous frantic fear of death he had forced on her, he hadn’t hurt her. Not physically. His words had pummeled her brutally, however.

The door behind the woman opened and she saw Professor Carmichael with a beaming smile. “Ms. Becker,” he boomed, and held the door and gestured inward toward his office with a flourish.

She rose, straightened her skirt, fought the urge to reciprocate with a smile. Today was not about smiles. She passed below him and entered his wood-paneled office, a well-appointed corner unit and to the right she could continue watching those boys play soccer if she wished.

Professor Carmichael said, “I was so glad to see that you had called. I’d hoped you would. When I saw your name on the list this morning I asked Isabel to put you down *today*. I have a class in half an hour but I really did want to talk to you. Please have a seat,” he gestured toward the one that sat across from his desk and he went around and plopped himself in the leather swivel on the other side. It squeaked with his weight. He was a big man, even bigger than Jay. Dressed as she’d seen him that day at Drillfield in Brattleboro. Tweed coat, tailored shirt with French cuffs, a flash of satin braces under his jacket.

He said, “Well now, what have you been considering postgrad?”

Maggie sat down, and put her hands together in her lap, chin lowered, gaze on Prof. Carmichael. She said, "I'm not here to talk about what I want to do after graduation."

"You're not?" he said raising one eyebrow, still smiling.

"No, Professor Carmichael, I'm not here for that at all. I know what I'm doing next year."

He smiled wider, said, "And what is that?"

"Harvard Law. I take the LSAT in January."

Professor Carmichael beamed, made the gesture of applause without actually clapping his hands, and leaned forward in his chair. "I'm so glad to hear that, Margaret."

"I am as well. I'm looking forward to it," she said grimly.

He studied her for a moment then he said, "What can I do to help you?"

"I'm here to talk to you about Jay."

Meat Lover

MONDAY, OCTOBER 23RD

HE'D SLIPPED out of the motel room in the middle of the night, awash in shame. He'd woken to find Maggie cuddled between him and Cole. She still faced Cole, and Cole's hand gripped her narrow waist.

He rose, and though everything told him to stay with her when she needed him, he was ashamed. He'd been caught. She knew that he'd hidden in her room that day. Hadn't come right out and said it, but he didn't want to wake up in the morning and hear the horrible things she might say. He would probably deserve it.

The original intention was to leave and return to his dorm room. But it was 5 A.M. and the Dunkin' Donuts across the street, next to the Subway, was open. He ordered coffee and a cruller and he went through his phone. He tried to come up with so many excuses. That seemed to be his natural operating mode. Dishonesty. What was he going to do ...? ... come up with some lies to make him not sound like a horrible voyeur? How he was maybe looking for, like, a can opener in Jessie's closet and then fell asleep only to wake and see his girlfriend with another boy?

That day Maggie would've been the guilty one. But he committed so many crimes against her in that time that her indiscretion was pale and innocent in comparison.

So he sat and he drank three cups of coffee. At seven in the morning, he had a bagel with cream cheese. The rest of that time was spent facing up to the bad things he'd done.

What would he admit to? The hiding. She knew that now. Would she remember then that she had masturbated afterward? Would she recall that

she lay in her bed and spread her little pussy with her fingers and masturbated while she thought of Jay? That her sneaky Max sat and watched her do something so personal.

How about all his manipulations thereafter? The innocent: *Oh gosh, I'd really like to see with him if you feel inexperienced.* All the times he let Maggie tell half-truths—when he knew the whole truth. Would she remember the things she said? Remember and then be embarrassed? Sure, she should be, but he felt shitty to be the one to make her feel that way.

Would she remember all the things he said, pleading with her, to get her to sleep with Jay? Wouldn't she then wonder why, if he had seen her play with that guy's balls, he'd be aroused and want to see more? Then she would realize something he was only beginning to admit: All of this, the whole time, had been about Max.

The things she had done with Cole she did on her own. But he'd booked a room in The Poirot for his best friend to fuck her. He'd tricked her into feeling seduced, feeling worthwhile, all for his own erotic benefit. He sat in an armoire and watched his best friend pretend to sweep her off her feet and fuck her in a way she'd never been before. He'd lied to himself saying it was for her benefit. Let Cole convince him of something he deep down wanted. The cold ugly truth was that was all for him.

After last night's painful revelation, Maggie was beginning to see it. And she would deduce more.

He was lost in thought for a long while but his eyes rose at a figure walking down the hill from the motel. It was his Maggie, a bag thrown over her shoulder, heading back to campus in the dark dawn. Alone. Without Cole.

He scrambled out of the booth and followed. Kept a good distance behind her as she walked to the Main Street village and onto campus. He should've left it there, gone back to Samuelson, gone to bed.

Maggie went back to her dorm room. She went back to her own space and she was probably going to get ready for class. But he didn't go back to his dorm, and it wasn't until later he realized that he was up to his old tricks again. Treachery. Spying.

And soon he was following her despite that. Unable to stop himself. Maggie wasn't dressed for class. She was dressed for something else and he was curious. Her hair pulled back neatly, a tight, braided bun, a light touch of makeup. Looking a little like the night she had gone out with Cole to The

Poirot. She was dressed smartly and professionally, and he followed behind in the wake of her clicking heels.

When she went into Winslow he sat outside and waited.

Now here she was emerging. While she'd been in there it occurred to him whose office was there. Could she be going to see Professor Carmichael? To what end? What would she say to him? He couldn't shake the sudden unwanted yet arousing image of her on her knees under his desk and sucking his massive Bajan cock.

"Fuck," he whispered, castigating himself. That's all he could come up with? His beloved Maggie went to Winslow and that means she's sucking a Professor's cock?

Whatever it was that had transpired within the halls of Winslow it seemed to be powerful. Maggie trotted down the steps, down to the concrete walk, weaving in between the other bustling students. When she came to a clear space, she stopped. He saw that her cheeks were rosy, her face flushing, her mouth agape. She stared to the sky. Then she bent over with her hands on her knees and he swore that she was hyperventilating.

Max was hidden behind the trunk of a beech tree, hands in pockets, collar of his duffel coat turned up. It was cold out today, and he huddled in his coat. He had the urge to just end this. Wanted to cross the walk and support her like he always had before. But then she would know she'd been followed. Her creepy Max up to his subterfuge.

His behavior, he realized, was the kind of thing that one could grow tired of. So his heart swelled in his chest while he watched her from a distance. Then she transformed. The hyperventilation ceasing, her body straightening. She smoothed her palms over her cheeks, blinking away tears. Her mouth, still agape, turned into a smile. He could tell she was sniffing, then it became a laugh. Now he felt better, wished again that he could just go to her. Sharing the good news and the bad. That's all he ever wanted. She hopped up and down three times, enough that he could hear the clap of her heels across the distance that separated them. She wiped at her brow with the back of her sleeve, then pumped her fist three times as she began striding the path, fishing her phone from a pocket and tapping away.

He followed along behind her at a safe distance until she stopped at the edge of the park where it met the main thoroughfare from the village into campus. She sat down on a metal bench and fiddled with her phone. Max wandered the path, wary of getting too close. Realized then that: *Well, hey,*

he was on campus. He was a student at Farmingham. He was just walking along and he saw her.

Look, here he was lying again. But he wanted to be back in her life. He'd excised himself, not even twelve hours now and he was dying without her. So he picked up his pace and he strode in a straight line towards the bench, practicing his startled *Hi! What are you doing here?*

As he drew near, a taxicab pulled up to the curb and she rose, trotted quickly to the rear passenger side and jumped in. He pivoted a hundred-and-eighty degrees and walked the opposite way, huddled deeper into his coat and flipped up its hood. The taxicab passed along on his left hand side and he turned his face away.

MAX MOUNTED the three steps to the first floor balcony of the Twilight, paper bag over his forearm with four pre-made Altieri's Deluxe Meat Lover's pizza slices inside.

His lies had to stop. Whatever elliptical pattern his current relationship with Maggie took, putting it back in proper orbit required brutal honesty. On his part, primarily. First things first, he had to apologize to Cole. The insult he hurled last night begged for a punch in the stomach and while he didn't like it, he appreciated the lesson. He'd done things to poison others against Cole and he didn't deserve what Max had said.

Hung from the handle of the door to their room was a DO NOT DISTURB card with a polite looking hand held up to halt. Three doors to his right a housekeeping cart was parked outside an open room. Latin music bashed quietly from a portable radio propped next to a tub with a feather duster fanned out the top. Syncopated underneath and out of time with the music he heard high moans gasping behind the door to Room 7. Guts turned to lead he swiped his room card through the lock and entered despite the card's instruction. He knew what he would find.

He slipped in sneakily and let the door close behind him. Maggie and Cole were making love in the bed. He'd just seen her fifteen minutes ago on campus, fully clothed and made up. On the floor, between Max and the bed, lay Maggie's clothing. Leather loafers, one laying on its side, leggings

pulled inside out, shirt, skirt, sweater, panties and bra; all making a trail to where two naked figures lay conjoined on the bed.

Cole lay on his back and Max's fiancée straddled his hips, her back toward the door so Max could see where she was skewered by his best friend's tremendous girth. It must've felt pretty good because she made ecstatic, joyous noises. Gasping "Yes, yes, yes," as she bounced on his cock, her haunches shaking. Maggie controlled the pace, did the fucking, while Cole looked in her eyes. Behind her head, Cole's hands worked at releasing her braids from the bun. When they were free, hanging over her shoulders, he pried them loose by running his fingers through them while she continued to bounce and squawk on him. A thick line of sticky white cream from Maggie rung the base of Cole's shaft and dripped down to collect on his scrotum between his sagging testicles.

"Oh, fuck, mm," she gasped, her head nodding forward, her bouncing stopping as she instead squeezed her thighs against his sides and swiveled. Her nails raked his chest. Cole's hands swept her waist then palmed the globes of her ass. He slapped her cheek, making her laugh. Her hips rolled on him now like a burlesque dancer, his fat cock buried in her pussy.

"Oh, my God, you feel so amazing," she hissed.

Cole said, "Mm, you feel so fucking good on me."

She chuckled, hips rocking, her hands rubbing over his chest and shoulders.

Max heard her say: "Put it in my ass."

With his eyes on Maggie's, Cole reached around her thigh, his thumb hooking around the base of his cock and plucking it out from inside her. It shone with wet, leaving a trail across the cheek of her ass. He stroked it up her crack, and she tilted forward and he used the pads of his fingers to push the head of his cock into her anus.

"Oh, shit, oh, wow," she grunted, her hair falling around Cole's face. "Mm, that's it."

Cole eased his hips up off the bed and Maggie reversed herself so he could plunge into her. It made a slick crackling sound, and they had to go slow, but Maggie let out a long, pleased sigh.

"Okay, mm, okay, hold it ..." Maggie grunted and sat upright and Max watched Cole's cock disappear up inside her. She squashed right down so she sat on him. Cole stroked her thighs, eyes glued to her, then smoothing up her ribs to cover her breasts. Maggie's nipples were hard, extended buds.

Max was crushed. Everything about this was awful. His heart hurt despite the arousal he felt between his legs. This was all too much now. They'd gone too far, and he'd allowed it. Racing a high-horsepower car on a wet, cliff-side road, all that protected him from death was a flimsy aluminum guardrail. Now he was plummeting.

He watched as Cole put his hand between them, in the 'V' of her parted thighs, his palm upward. Max knew he was fingering her while he fucked her ass. His best friend had his cock up inside his fiancée, his fingers curled up inside her pussy, and the most hurtful...? ... The blazing eye contact between the two of them.

Maggie leaned back, her hands walking down Cole's thighs and holding onto his knees, her twisted, tangled, half-braided hair swaying behind her. Her chin pointed up to the ceiling and Max saw her beautiful face. She was in ecstasy. Cole's shoulder muscles jumped as he flicked and buzzed Maggie's clit, his two middle fingers shoved inside her. Max watched his lover's face as her mouth fell open, watched as her tummy rolled and bulged and heaved, her hips rocking, her breath coming faster and faster and then she came. He dropped the pizza on the floor.

"Oh, Jesus Christ," Cole said seeing him now standing by the door. "This fucking ..."

Maggie was still coming, her face troubled but pleased, wincing and snarling, her breasts shaking. Cole watched Max, and he was mad.

Max crossed the room in five steps to stand next to the bed. Looked down and saw his best friend's neck and face smattered with mouth prints in the shade of lipstick that his Maggie had applied this morning. His chest bore furry red lines from where she had scratched him while they fucked. His friend was flush, his chest sweaty and reddened. Maggie's as well, her creamy bosom blossomed with rose. Her eyes fluttered, and she registered that the man to whom she was betrothed was here.

"Max," she gasped. "Max ... Oh, ah, mm, I won, Max, I ..."

Cole said, "Max—what the fuck ...? Get out of here ..."

Maggie's hips still moiled and he could hear a wet sucking sound from where they were connected. Her eyes were glassy, and she gasped his name again, a hand reaching out to touch him.

Cole said, "Max, come on, go, get out of here ..."

Max said, "I will. I'll get out of here after I get what I came for."

Max was in motion before he'd made the decision to act. Yet he knew now what he would do.

Cole propped himself up on his elbows, said, "What's that?"

Max took Maggie's wrist as she reached to him, pressed his thumb into the centre of her palm and it curled her fingers. He saw the ring he and his brothers had gone out that special day in Michigan and purchased. He got down on one knee by the gazebo in the village, presented it to her and asked her to marry him. She said *Yes, a thousand times yes*. He was in love with her and he was sure she was in love with him. But it couldn't be like this. Not like this. His fingers circled the ring, the sharp edges of the diamond digging into the webbing of his thumb.

Maggie resisted, her eyes going from glassy to alert in an instant. "Shit, no, no, Max!" She pulled her hand, but he held her by the wrist and tugged at the ring. She fought him, grabbing his shirt with her other hand, pleading with him: "Max, Maxy, don't be crazy, Max, don't, please, Max ... don't, Max, I'm so sorry, I'm so sorry, God, I mean it ..."

He was grim and voiceless. He focused everything on the object he wished to retrieve. Maggie fell off Cole, his wet dick slapping up on his belly.

Cole said, "Don't fight, Maggie, just let him ..."

"No, Max, seriously, Max, that's my ring ... don't take my beautiful ring ..."

He had it now, it was up past her knuckle. She began to cry, tears coming down her cheeks, her face beet red in an instant, her nose shiny, lips puffed.

"Please, Max, I'm begging you, don't ..."

"Don't fight, Maggie," Cole said, and he held her by her waist, sitting up now. The ring came free, clutched in his hand. He looked down on them. These two lovers. His handsome best friend and the girl he loved deeply. Arm in arm, embracing, naked, flushed from sex, wet with excitement.

The ring pressed against his flesh he clutched it so hard. He crushed harder until his hand shook.

Maggie bawled. Burst into tears, fell forward and Cole had to hold her before she collapsed on the carpet.

"Easy, Maggie, easy," Cole soothed her.

She wailed into her hands and Max cried, too. He'd wanted to hurt her. Wanted to hurt her so bad, and this was the only thing he could think of. It

felt so good in the moment. It still felt good.

Cry. Cry for me, Maggie. Feel what it's like without me.

He turned on his heel and left them. Marched past the pizza slices he dropped on the floor, the lunch he'd intended to share when he would sit with Cole and say he was sorry. But it was all gone now. All of it. He opened the door, slammed it behind him. Walked out into the crisp noontime cold.

By the time he was down the steps and halfway across the parking lot he realized his heart was broken. He knew he just made the biggest mistake of his life.

Afterword

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Other Books by KT Morrison

LANDLORD Series

[Owing Reza](#)

[Reza's Coming](#)

It's the first of the month and that means Reza is coming.

Jonny and Charlie Keen got themselves in financial trouble. Well, that was Jonny's fault. But sweet Charlie has a way to keep them in the apartment they love. And despite how terrible it may seem, it's still a better option than the two of them stumbling back to her parent's Kansas farm and telling them what a failure Jonny is.

She'll submit to Reza, their landlord's son. Jonny will watch as another man takes care of his woman in every way she needs. It's the first of the month and this is the way it is now.

MAGGIE Series

[Tempting Maggie](#)

[Sharing Maggie](#)

[Secret Maggie](#)

[Exploring Maggie](#)

[Discovering Maggie](#)

Max is a fourth year Government and Policy student engaged to wed the love of his life.

Maggie is a fourth year Art student and she can't wait for the summer to come so she can finally tie the knot with the guy she fell in love with when they were Freshmen.

They've been together four years at their prestigious private college nestled in the Green Mountains of Vermont. This is the year they'll graduate and set out into the world together as a couple.

But Maggie is surprised to find her desires set on fire by a gorgeous new figure model. She thinks she'd never cheat but she can't stop thinking about him.

When Max learns her secret he's crushed. It tears down everything he knows about her. But in the rubble he finds something shining: excitement.

Now, if he could just convince her it's okay...

Learning Lessons

A Losing His Wife Novel

This long series is now one novel! A 160,000 word cuckold tragedy ...

Pete and Jess Mapplethorpe have been married for seven years now. They've got two wonderful little boys and an Irish Setter. Everyone that knows them would say they are the nicest couple you'd want to meet.

Well, they might say that Pete can be a bit of a jerk sometimes—but Jess? Regional Grade Three teacher of the year, three years running. Pretty, polite, sensitive, kind and thoughtful...

It must have been black magic that brought them together...

Behind closed doors everyone would be shocked at what goes on. They'd never believe the dirty things that sweet Jess might do or say. Pete doesn't think he has what it takes to please his beautiful wife and they fantasize about larger men taking her and making her happy.

She's just starting to discover herself at thirty-five... She wants to make up for lost time.

They've found a handsome, well-built young man to play along. It's better than they even imagined. Now that they've started will she be able to stop? What if she doesn't want to?

Her husband loves enduring distressing levels of humiliation and she's finding a crazy pleasure now in delivering it...

Cherry Blossoms

A Losing His Wife Novel

This long series is now one novel! A 300,000 word cuckold tragedy ...

Geoff J. Kane is a successful children's book illustrator. Ten years ago he married the girl of his dreams. She'd been his best friend and he'd helped her through tough relationships and gave her his shoulder to cry on many nights. Then after two years, she kissed him. Now they're married and they've got a beautiful seven-year-old daughter.

Nia Kane was a wild one. She liked to have fun and she liked to cause trouble. Everything she did, in the end, blew up in her face, hurt her. One night she realized the best man in her life was sitting with her, telling her it was all going to be okay. She kissed him and it was wonderful and he's always good to her.

Their daughter is growing up, she's away at school now and it seems like it might be a good idea for Nia to return to the workforce. The city isn't getting any cheaper. She gets a job offer from an old friend. The brother of her very hot ex-boyfriend. She cried on her husband's shoulder a lot over this guy, back when Geoff was just her buddy.

Having her ex back in her life stirs up old feelings in both of them. They both like it. There was something exciting about that time when they were twenty. It's safe now. He's got her. They can fantasize, right?

Obsessed Series

Obsessed: Book One

Obsessed: Book Two

Four couples lives intertwine as they explore their erotic boundaries. From simple wife-watching to cuckolding and domination and humiliation, these couples have one thing in common: they all share the same incredible bull. And he is far more than they even expected.

Mike and Gretch: Not married, but dating for a good long while. Two comedy writers just at the edge of love, that strange and delicate space where the act of sharing can be so dangerous. But they're two cool cats and they're sure they've got it all locked down. They call her ex-boyfriend from college, Atticus Hawke, a guy who has in the years since their breakup, and before Mike, been a reliable booty call for her.

Sean and Courtney: Sean's a Type A stick of dynamite. A rocketing studio exec, competitive and driven, he shares an incredible bond with his gym-toned wife. Courtney is all in for the new game she and her handsome husband have devised. Their ten-year-old daughter is out of the house and away at boarding school. They've planned a one-year commitment to one another about honesty, openness, and exploration. They're going for broke. Their new thing? Sean likes to watch and Court likes to be watched. They've found a guy online. He seems too good to be true. A guy called Finch, endowed, muscular, handsome like a fashion model. Courtney's been working out and she's going to put this stud through his paces.

Steve and Becky: Becky's a headstrong X-Ray technician who landed herself a multi-millionaire tech investor husband thirty years her senior. Steve loves to be dominated and he found the girl of his dreams in Becky. She's got an iron will and she loves her husband. Loves him enough to lock him in chastity and keep him abstinent for months on end. It's okay, don't worry about Becky, she gets a regular visit from a drop-dead gorgeous man named Finch. He keeps her satisfied. Sometimes, if he's been good, she'll even let her husband watch.

JJ and Amy: Two young country bumpkins just arrived in Los Angeles. JJ wants to live a lifestyle he's only dreamed of and this city is part of it. He's married to the sweetest little nineteen-year-old outta Jackson Pond, South Carolina and he's sure she's on a fast ticket to stardom. She just needs her first big break. While they're waiting he's got a fantasy he wants to see lived out. He would do anything to see his little Amy with a man who's got a big one, one'll make her scream like those girls he watches on the internet. He found a guy online, one Amy didn't make her vomit-face at. He's got everything JJ's been looking for and, thank the stars, he's agreed to do it.

Atticus Hawke: Finch is his online name. His nighttime name. The one he uses on a site that puts him in touch with couples looking for a bull just like him. By day he is Atticus Hawke. You might have heard of him. You know the song from the eighties, 'Going With That Girl'? No? You'd know it if you heard it. That was Atticus' dad, Ricky Hawke. Yes, that Ricky Hawke. Now you know. Made a bunch of singer-songwriter hits in a time when all the kids wanted pop coming out of synthesizers and their stars to be pretty boys and have colourful hair. Ricky had real talent. So does Atticus. One of L.A.'s hottest emerging Modern artists, his work commands a fortune. But it pales against his enormous trust fund. These days his real work is done at night. His masterpieces. That's where his passion is. Watching and participating in intense psychological dramas in dark hotel rooms across the city. He gives women what they want. They're a canvas, a medium. His audience: their husband.

The Cayman Proxy Series:

The Cayman Proxy (Box One)

Mitchell Sutton's family is one of the wealthiest in London. But Mitch is an outsider, the handsome young son who took his own path. He's in love with a girl from the wrong side of the tracks. Kate's a troubled Council house girl thrown into a lifestyle she never imagined. But she's more than his dressed up little princess. He's got just about everything she needs. But she's got a mind full of dark thoughts she can't escape. And there's something Mitch can't give her. She needs something his money can't buy. He would do anything for her. They hit the hot beaches of Grand Cayman, a reunion with an old friend and a handsome stranger. Passion boils in her blood. Can she make this work or will her desires destroy the man she loves?



Pool Party

A cuckold thriller.

Darren's wife is far away this weekend at a conference in New York City. At least that's what she told him. Who knows these days? He's got a sneaking suspicion Lynn's been cheating on him. Nothing concrete; little things. Like the gym dedication, the slim-fitting new clothes ... there's an attitude as well. And she's been denying him his marital pleasures. A distance has been growing between them though they've been happily married for twenty-five years. Today's the hottest day of the summer. A hundred-and-five degrees, and at Darren's house it's about to get even hotter ... A fortuitous knock on the door brings Darren surprises and clues to the mysteries that have been keeping him awake ... He worried his imagination had been getting away from him ... Sometimes the worst thing you can imagine isn't even close.



Going A Little Too Far

You couldn't picture a sweeter couple than Troy and Emma. Troy's a former Division One college wrestler. A walking water park at two-sixty-five, with shoulders no woman could get her arms around and a set of abs you could scrub laundry on. Emma's a sweet little Georgia Peach. Pretty as can be in her proper dresses; she's a good girl from a good family that raised her right.

You couldn't tell by looking at them that they were two straight-up freaks that loved to push each other's kinky buttons.

Emma, with all her book club shyness, loves to be man-handled, loves to be lifted off her feet and dominated. Troy is a monster with a six-hundred-fifty pound deadlift and she's like a feather in his arms.

Troy likes to be humiliated. He knows he doesn't have much 'down there' and he likes his virginal wife to tell him he's no good and she'd have to get what she wanted elsewhere.

Couple of closet freaks.

A summer housewarming party on a scorching hot West Texas day puts a gift in their lap. A big, larger-than-life playtoy for Emma to tease her husband with. He wants her to. She wants to do it. But once it starts, where do you stop? What's going too far?

Taken While He Watches: On Their Honeymoon

Ken and Ashley just got married and while money is super-tight they've got themselves a weekend getaway in the Honeymoon Suite looking out over the ocean on the sunny Carolina coast.

The room was a steal. Turns out it's Bike Week and no one books the Honeymoon Suite during Bike Week. Especially not two dopey white kids from the suburbs.

A mix-up leaves them in trouble and they don't know how they can get out of it, don't even know how they'll get home. They get some help from their hotel neighbours. A half dozen handsome, muscular, and very wealthy black men.

Ken's wary but Ash is all in.

When they find out she's saved herself for her special night she becomes the star of the show and they'll offer anything to help her...

Ken doesn't like it but she's going to do what they ask. She says it's for their future...

Taken While He Watches: At The Combine

Coralee has put her own career on hold to help her husband keep his Sports Podcast afloat. He's spent eighty grand on his tiny entertainment empire.

Bobby just needs a big break. His business is a half second away from going belly-up. When their camera captures an XXL wardrobe malfunction by the combine's star prospect they see an opportunity.

Coralee will do anything to get an interview with him. She'll use the video as leverage. She'll get to this bad boy super-athlete, even if she has to break into the locker room...

She's doing it to save the family business, right?

Taken By His Best Friends: At The Hockey Rink

Marguerite was a sexy little French student Randall fell in love with at college. She loved hockey. He played hockey.

They fell in love and they married. They live a regular 9 to 5 now, but Randall and his best friends still play once a week. They are four big guys and they play rough and Marguerite is always there to cheer them from the stands.

When they all end up alone in the locker room after a bench-clearing brawl passions are already high. And when some innocent flirting starts it quickly tumbles out of control.

Marguerite does nothing to stop it. Randall is frozen...

He's going to watch his best friends do all the dirty things they've ever dreamed of doing to his wife...

Measured Next To Her Ex: A Medical Size Comparison Cuckold Fantasy

When Ben Watson went to the new Sexual Performance Clinic across from his office he was just looking to get some help.

But when he showed up on Opening Day the place was so overwhelmed they started doubling up in exam rooms to make sure all the patients were assessed.

Of all the gin joints in all the—

Guess who his exam partner is? Yeah, his honey-pie's ex-boyfriend. He is going to be sitting next to him, knees practically touching, while these nurses assess their size and performance using only their latex hands.

He could leave, get the hell out of there. That would be sensible. But he's kind of curious. A dark part of him wants to know something. Wants to know what his precious girl's ex-lover has between his legs.

He's going to wish he left.

Then, when his obscenely endowed exam mate starts to relate to the nurses the casual but very dirty hook-ups he's been having with an ex, Ben's hands really start sweating.

This is going to be the worst day of Ben's life.

Size Curious Brat

Matt Walsh is on his way home from Harvard. It's Thanksgiving recess and he hasn't been with his sweet Chloe Rose in months. He can't wait to get off the bus and wrap his arms around his baby girl.

Chloe's a perverted little high-schooler with a habit for trouble. She loves her boyfriend Matt and she's been aching for him.

But there's a problem.

Matt's step brother came home early. He's a bully. A domineering man's man who made Matt's life miserable growing up. Now he's a sexy deep-sea welder just getting home from Louisiana after two months at sea and he hasn't even seen a woman in ages.

After a brief, naked encounter in the hallway little Chloe can't get something out of her mind. Matt's stepbrother Moric is built much better than other men and she can't stop thinking about it.

It makes Matt mad but Chloe is just naturally curious. She doesn't think it's a big deal. She's just never seen anything like that before.

Now Moric's got his eyes on his little brother's prize possession. She's not exactly unwilling. Moric is a big powerful stud and Matt is powerless to stop him. Once he starts neither of them could stop him. He could take whatever he wants. It might be better—if Moric would let him—to just join him...